Not All Heroes Wear Capes

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30064161.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Scorpia (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Pretty much everyone is here, Except for Swift Wind

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Catra is She-Ra, Alternate Universe - Adora Remains with the Horde (She-Ra), Adora and Scorpia are Bros, Glimmer and Catra are feral, Catra "How dare you infect me with morals" Applesauce, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Season 1, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Tags Are Hard, Lighthearted, Slow Updates, Dialogue Heavy, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, headcanons, Mostly Canon Compliant, Angst, abandoned work

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by TheTokenAro

Summary

Deep in the Whispering Woods, centuries ago, a sword was damaged. And a spirit began to slip through the cracks.

It wasn't free, not quite. Still tied to the prison they created.

The two who would make history came to the world. It knew which one she wanted. But it had a choice now.

So it made one.

(Abandoned Cuz lack of motivation and also I can't write romance :P)

- Inspired by [Restricted Work] by catrasredemption (Samonymity)
- Inspired by You Came Back (For Me?) by genVicron

Cover

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes



Chapter End Notes

I finally figured it out and got the picture up! I put so much effort into this. Also my gosh is it hard to draw sword

Curiosity Killed the Cat

Deep in the Whispering Woods, centuries ago, a sword was damaged. And a spirit began to slip through the cracks.

It wasn't free, not quite. Still tied to the prison *they* created.

The two who would make history came to the world. It knew which one *she* wanted. But it had a choice now.

So it made one.

"I take it back, you're officially awesome.", Catra declared as they zoomed out of the Fright Zone, "I can't believe you stole a skiff!"

"Borrowed.", Adora corrected, "Please don't make me regret this."

It didn't take long for them to start bickering over the steering shaft, swerving left and right. Catra didn't even notice where they were heading until Adora shoved her out of the way and slowed them to a stop.

She glanced up to see a tangled forest. "This must be the Whispering Woods.", Adora murmured, "They say there's horrible monsters in there a-and the trees move when you're not looking."

Catra looked into the dark woods, unknown creatures skittering about. She felt something pull at her core. A grin spread across her face.

"Let's go in."

"What?"

She didn't let Adora protest before she took back the shaft and sped right into the trees. She weaved through the trunks, Adora's screams accompanying her laughter.

“Tree! Tree!” She didn’t move fast enough. The skiff slammed into the tree, sending her tumbling to the ground.

Her vision went black for a moment, then was replaced with the sight of the canopy. Groaning, she sat up, looking for the skiff.

It was nowhere in sight.

“Adora?”, she called out. No reply. Fear started to build in her. She should wait where she was. It’d be easier for Adora to find her. Unless she had been hurt in the crash worse than she was…

With that thought, she started frantically searching, straining to hear Adora amongst the wildlife. She spotted a light through the trees. Wondering if it was a signal or if she reached the edge of the forest, she rushed towards it.

She pushed the brush out of the way, only to be met with a glowing sword, a cracked, blue gem on the hilt.

The glow entranced her, calling her forward. All thoughts of panic and her friend became background noise in her mind as she moved towards it. When she gripped the handle, white enveloped her vision.

A figure stood in front of her, seemingly made of golden light. It held out a hand. She instinctively went to take it, but before she could, static filled her ears, a voice clipping through.
“Bal...mus...be restored…..seek a hero...Ador….ora!”

The last part kept repeating, the word not fully coming in.

Ad---a----Atr---Ca--ra

Catra

“Catra!”

Her eyes flew open, nearly throwing Adora back as she shot up.
“I--wh-what?”, she stammered.

“Are you alright?” Her head jerked up to Adora, her words quieting her scrambling thoughts.

“Yeah, I’m fine.”, she brushed off. Adora didn’t seem convinced. “You sure? You fell a long way.”

“I’m *fine* .”, she snapped, standing up, “Let’s just go back.”

They rode in silence, Catra ignoring the new feeling beneath her skin.

Catra. Catra. Catra!

She gasped, sitting upright, her fur bristling. Her eyes darted around the room, finding no source for the voice that was plaguing her.

Her breathing slowed, but her shoulders stayed stiff. She sat there for a minute, drinking in the quiet.

Then she got up.

It was stupid idea. The thought repeated in her head like a mantra even as she dug the keys out of Adora’s stuff.

There was no reason for her to be sneaking around in the docking bay. Still, she felt the skiff rumble to life beneath her feet.

The wind whipped in her hair as she shot straight towards the woods, this time landing just outside of it before continuing on foot. Despite all the life surrounding her, she still felt deafening silence. She mumbled to herself to fill the air.

“This is crazy. You're crazy. Who cares about a stupid sword anyway, it probably wasn’t even real. Just go home before you get yourself killed.”

Not even speaking the thoughts out loud stopped her from moving forward.

She kept pushing on until finally she came across the object that had sent her on this crazed trek.

There was no reason to feel a need for *that* specific sword. But she did. She started towards it, then froze.

There were people close by. Very close by.

"Just let me lead the way, ok?"

"The light's coming from the east..."

Catra stumbled back, scrambling to look for a hiding place. How had they snuck up on her, *she* was the one with superior hearing.

Before she could leap up a tree or something, the two people stepped into the clearing. They stalled, staring at her. Then the purple one shouted, "Horde Soldier!"

She dove for the sword, only for Purple to slam into her, throwing them to the side. Catra shoved her off and ran back.

But apparently Sparkles here could fucking *teleport* and pulled the sword out of the roots, throwing it to Arrow who fumbled in catching it.

Catra rushed towards him, then yowled in pain as Sparkles jumped on her back and started pulling at her hair. She bucked her off and leapt onto Arrow, knocking them to the ground and the sword away.

Sparkles landed back on her, them both pinning her down. She reached for the sword, her fingertips brushing the handle.

Light shot out.

Catra blinked, finding herself in a crystalline area fading in and out of static. A voice rang out.

"Hello, Catra."

Said girl jumped to her feet, turning to see a tall, blue woman. "My name is Light Hope.", she continued, "I've been waiting a long time for someone to forge a connection with the sword."

Catra was at a loss for words. All she wanted was to get a sword, what was all this?

The woman seemed unbothered by her confusion. "Etheria is in need of you, Catra. Will you answer it's call? Will you fight for the honor of Grayskull?"

She didn't get a chance to reply before the world faded completely and she fell from it's grasp.

She was once again met with the sight of indigo trees.

"She's awake!" Catra winced at the exclamation, shoving Arrow out her face. It quickly became apparent she was tied up.

His face was soon replaced by Sparkles. "How did you make it this far into the Whispering Woods?"

"I walked in? It's not that hard."

"Sure, sure, sure. You *just so happened* to find yourself in the Whispering Woods, like you *just so happened* to steal our sword."

"If you care so much about it, why'd you leave it in the middle of the woods for anyone to take?"

Sparkles chose to ignore that perfectly valid point, and turned to Arrow. "Come on Bow, let's take her back to Bright Moon where she can be interrogated properly."

Arrow pulled her up and they started walking. Sparkles leaned closer to him. “This is perfect!”, she cheered in a whisper, “Not only did we find First Ones’ tech, we also have a Horde spy! Mom’s gonna be so impressed.”

Catra felt a sting of some emotion, but quickly stamped it down, trading it for a small laugh. “You’re doing all this to impress your mom?” Sparkles jumped, not expecting her to be listening. “Shut it, Horde Scum!”, she snapped.

Catra rolled her eyes and kept walking.

Now, from an outside view, she seemed pretty relaxed about the whole situation. Really, she was anything but.

Shadow Weaver was going to kill her. That bitch had been waiting for an excuse to get rid of her for years, sneaking out and getting captured by the rebellion would certainly be a viable one.

Even if her captors didn’t seem all that great at their job.

“Are you *sure* we’re going the right way?” “It’s fine, ok? Just let me figure this out.”

Arrow fell in step with her. “Sorry about her, she’s usually nice.”

Catra didn’t reply.

“Not much for talking, huh?” “What, are your prisoners usually *friendly*?”

He made a face. “Well, I’ve never actually taken anyone prisoner before.” “Clearly.”

They bumped into Sparkles, who was looking out at a ruin. Catra glanced over the buildings. Didn’t seem like anything special. Just a broken town.

“So, are we just standing here or...?” That appeared to be the wrong thing to say. Sparkles whipped around to face her, rage

painted on her face.

“How *dare* you! How can you just look at your destruction and act like it’s nothing?”

Catra glared back. “It’s a *war* , princess. Something’s gonna get broken along the way.”

“And you don’t even care?”

“It’s not my life, why should I?”

Glimmer’s look was murderous, but it didn’t deter Catra. She’d seen worse.

Arrow interrupted their deathly staring contest. “Ok, maybe we should go *around* …”

Sparkles marched ahead of them, disappearing into the brush. A moment later, she came running back. “There’s something out there.”, she said, panic clear, “Something big.”

“How big?” His question was answered with a tremor and a giant bug monster emerging from the bushes with a screech.

It brought one of its legs down, causing them to scatter. The sword was also dropped. Catra immediately grabbed and started running. She stopped when she heard yelling.

Glimmer was sending a barrage of magic blasts at the creature to no avail, the same going for Bow’s arrows. They were cornered.

Catra turned away again, getting only a few steps before she hesitated. With a curse, she ran back.

She launched herself at the monster, driving the sword into its head, then leaping back. Even that didn’t deter it, simply screeching once more and bringing a leg down on her. She held up the sword, straining to block.

The voice echoed in her head.

Will you fight for the honor of Grayskull?

With barely a second thought, she yelled, "For the Honor of Grayskull!"

The world went white.

"Uh, Glimmer…?"

"Yeah, I see her, Bow."

In the Horde soldier's place was a glowing figure dressed almost completely in white and gold, blond hair flowing in a magical wind.

The bug creature relaxed in her light, almost seeming to kneel before her despite said girl stabbing it in the head moments ago.

Everything was still, until the soldier finally noticed her growth spurt.

She screamed, falling to the ground and transformation washing away. Glimmer immediately teleported over and tried to take the sword.

"What did you do to me?!", the soldier screeched, refusing to give up the weapon. "What do you mean 'what did I do to you'?", Glimmer countered.

"You said it was *your* sword, didn't you?"

"Ok, everybody calm down!", Bow yelled, getting in between their tugging match. He leaned towards the soldier. "Mind telling us what you did?"

“I don’t know what I did! All I did was pick up that sword and then boom! I have a fucking crown!”

“Who cares how she did it, we just have to make sure she never does it again!” With one final tug, she wretched the sword away from the soldier.

Not a moment after did the bug stand back up.

Much screaming later, they tumbled into a ruin. The door closed behind them, the bug thumping into it a few times. With one final screech, they were left in silence.

The group let out a collective sigh of relief.

“How’d you do that?”, Bow asked the soldier.

“What?”

“How’d you open the door?” She seemed confused by that. “I just...read the word that was written on it?" “Right…”, Glimmer drawled, “You just read the writing of a language that’s been dead for thousands of years and led us into mysterious, ancient ruin.”

“Oh no, you figured it out. My master plan has been foiled.”, the soldier replied, her sarcasm almost painful.

Glimmer simply sent her another glare, then brushed past. “We need to start moving. The sooner we get out of here the better.”

Bow fell in step with the prisoner once again.

“Hey, so thanks for saving us from that bug thing when you could’ve escaped instead.”, he said, for some idiotic reason.

She could almost feel the soldier roll her eyes. “Yeah, well, it wouldn’t have taken long for it to pick off you two and come for me next.”

“Are you sure it’s not because you secretly like us?” The soldier laughed. “Is your plan to make me succumb to Stockholm Syndrome?” “What?”

After that was a moment of blissful silence. It didn’t last.

“I’m Bow by the way.” Glimmer would’ve argued that they shouldn’t share names, but they had been yelling them at each other the whole time.

The soldier took a moment to answer. “Catra.”

“I think we’re in a First One’s ruin.”, Glimmer interrupted a bit too loudly. “What’s that?”, Catra asked. Glimmer scoffed. “You’ve never heard of the First Ones?”

“The First Ones were the original settlers of Ethiera.”, Bow jumped to explain, “They left behind lots of old ruins and technology, like this place.”

“What happened to them?” “No one knows. They just disappeared one day. The Horde didn’t tell you about them?”

“There’s a lot the Horde doesn’t tell us.” A surprising amount of bitterness was laced in the statement.

They continued wandering for a while. They entered a big chamber and Glimmer let out a groan. “How do we get *out* of here?”

“It’ll take forever to get out at this rate.”, Bow replied. He turned to Catra. “Mind turning on some lights?”

“I don’t know how to do that.” “Maybe there’s a magic word. What’s the First One’s word for lights?”

She threw her hands up in exasperation. “How should I know, I’m not magic!” Glimmer rolled her eyes and stepped towards the center of the room. “Everyone stand back.”

“Uh, maybe you should take it easy.”, Bow interjected, “We don’t know how long it’ll be till you can recharge your powers.” The Horde Scum let out a laugh. “You have to recharge your powers?”

“Can we not talk about this right now?”, she grumbled, “Now stand back.”

She focused her energy into the palms of her hands. When she felt enough build up, she threw her magic into the air. It burst into a large ball of light, illuminating the room.

She stumbled over, Bow quick to catch her. Her eyes scanned the room. All it had were more doors that led to even more hallways and a mural on the wall.

“Oh hey.”, Bow elbowed Catra and pointed to the mural, “That looks like you.”

“That doesn’t look anything like me.”

“No, the other you that glowed.”

It did indeed look like her, though the mural had a red cape and wings on the crown.

Bow elbowed Catra again. “You can read that inscription, right?” She leaned forward and squinted at it.

“It says...She-ra.”

Just like that, the building came to life, the room flooding with light. A hologram appeared, causing them to jump back.

“ *What is your query?* ”

“What is that thing?”, Catra asked, leaning away. “I think it’s some sort of ancient hologram.”, Bow answered. He walked up to it. “Uh...Hi. What is this place?”

The hologram didn't reply. "How do we get out of here?". More silence, then, " *What is your query?* "

"Welp, she's broken." "She's old.", Glimmer said, stepping up to it as well, "I'm surprised anything in this place still works."

The hologram flashed red and spoke. " *Administrator not detected. Lockdown initiated.* "

"I didn't do it!", Glimmer immediately defended.

The lights went red, alarms blaring and the doors slamming closed. The building started shaking and debris fell from the ceiling.

"No no no, no lockdown. No lockdown.", Bow pleaded, "Catra, get it to stop." "What makes you think I know how?!", she demanded. "There's gotta be a password or something, just try!"

"Uh, Eternia? She-ra! Just stop it!" The room kept crumbling.

An idea flashed in Catra's eyes. "Give me the sword." " *What?!* ", Glimmer replied incredulously, holding the object further away.

"We need the glowy lady, she's obviously the key to this place, so give me the fucking sword!"

Glimmer looked between the sword and the crumbling room. She came to a decision. "You're a Horde soldier, I'm *not* giving it to you."

Instead, she grabbed the two and held them close. "Hang on." "Wait, no--"

Before Bow could protest further, they were falling through the air. She only felt it for a second and then passed out.

She woke up what felt like a moment later. She sat up and Bow practically teleported to her side. "Are you alright?"

“Yeah.”, she replied, still a bit out of breath from the magic and panic, “I’m fine.” He helped her up and she was surprised to see the Horde soldier standing off to the side.

“What are you still doing here?” Catra jerked up at the question, caught off guard.

“Uh, what do you mean?”

“Bow and I are hardly a crack security team. You could’ve left at any time. Why didn’t you?”

That was the question of the day, wasn’t it? Why the fuck was she still here? She could’ve left them to die with the bug monster and gone home with her prize. Maybe even earlier than that.

And yet she went back to save them and stuck around to wait for Sparkles to wake up. She could leave right at that second and yet...she didn’t want to. She wanted to keep going, to see where this all went.

She sighed and ran a hand through her hair. “I don’t know.”, she replied honestly.

The two got an odd look on their faces at that. Sparkle’s expression morphed back to being serious. “Come on. We’ve still got a long walk to Bright Moon.”

They weren’t great at hiding their shock of her following.

By the time they reached a village, the morning moon had fully risen. Definitely too late to go back to the Fright Zone without Shadow Weaver skinning her alive. She’d figure something out whenever she decided to ditch Arrow and Sparkles.

“Ok, belt comes off.”, Sparkles told her when they stopped at the edge of the town. “What, why?”, Catra demanded.

“If the people know you’re a Horde soldier, they’ll freak out. So the belt comes off.”

She sighed, unclipping the badge-thing instead. “Better?”

With an affirming nod from Sparkles, they set off into the town.

It wasn’t what she was expecting. People were setting up stands with stuff that smelled *really* good, others putting out tables, and most decorating their homes.

“Wow, if this is what everyone in Bright Moon does every morning, then that explains a lot.”, she commented.

“Well, they don’t do it *every* morning.”, Arrow corrected, “Just for festivals.”

“For what?”

“You know like a big party.”

Catra looked at him blankly. “You don’t have parties in the Fright Zone?”, he lamented in disbelief.

“Did you not hear me?”, Sparkles interrupted, “I said in and out!”

“But she’s never been to a party before, this is serious!” Before Catra knew it, she was being dragged around town.

The streets were dotted with dancers, music filling the air. Kids weaved through the forming crowds, laughing as they chased each other.

She got to eat some of the delicious smelling stuff, was bombarded by several kids, and was honestly...enjoying it. She was able to forget about the Horde and everything about it, if only for a little bit.

All those thoughts resurfaced when she heard explosions.

The group rushed for the noise, the atmosphere shifting as they arrived on the scene. “It’s the Horde!”, Sparkles yelled the obvious.

Another explosion went off and they ducked into a building. “Why are they here? The people of Thaymor aren’t a threat.” Catra’s eyes widened at Bow’s words.

“ *This* is Thaymor?”, she questioned. That couldn’t be right. It was just a small town, there was no advantage of taking it.

Glimmer marched up to her. “Do you know something about this?”

“No! Well, yes, my friend is leading it, but she wouldn’t do it if she knew what was really happening.” She started for the door. “I need to find her, if I tell her what’s going on, she’s sure to stop.”

She ran out onto the battlefield, searching the smoke for the signature poof of hair. People were crying out, tanks were rolling in, and smoke filled the sky. She didn’t understand, what was the point of attacking this place--

“Catra?”

She turned to the voice. Upon seeing the other, they didn’t waste a moment in closing the gap, holding each other in their arms.

“Oh Catra, I thought I lost you!”, Adora exclaimed, “You were gone when I woke up and no one knew where you were and I had to prepare for the invasion of Thaymor so I didn’t get a chance to look for you and--”

“Hey, Adora, it’s ok.”, she cut off the ramble, “I’m here now and everything is fine.”

Then she remembered the scene around them and her face turned serious. “You need to call off the invasion.”

Adora stepped back. “What?”

“There’s no rebel fortress, it’s just a town.”

She only stepped back further. “No, no, that can’t be right. The fortress is hidden, we’re *liberating* it--”

“You’re *destroying* it!”, Catra yelled, gesturing to the damage surrounding them, “Please, just call it off. You don’t want to do this, I know you’re not a bad person.”

“The Horde would never lie to us!”

“Of course they would! Shadow Weaver’s been in your head for years and you’re too stupid to see it!”

Adora’s eyes flicked around frantically, searching for something, anything, to argue with. Her eyes landed on Catra, skepticism starting to seep in. “Why are you in Thaymor?”

“What?”

A hand reached for her stun baton. “They did something to you, didn’t they? The Rebellion kidnapped you last night and brainwashed you.” “Adora, wait--”

Electricity coursed through her body and she crumpled to the ground.

“Don’t worry, you’ll be alright.”, she soothed, “We’ll take you back home, and Shadow Weaver can fix whatever those *monsters* did to you--”

She was cut off by a fist full of sparkles.

Catra strained herself up, watching an arrow whiz over head. It hit Adora, exploding into a net. She didn’t see the rest of the fight because Sparkles grabbed her and teleported away.

She fell back on the ground, disoriented. “Give a little warning next time, will you?”, she snarked. She looked up to see Glimmer sitting up against a house.

“We need you.”, she gasped out, “We need She-ra.” She unlooped the sword from her back and held it out to her. “I should’ve given this to you in the ruins, but I was stupid, and a jerk, and I’m *sorry-- ”*

“Woah hey calm down.”, she cut off, “You weren’t *that* much of a jerk. Well, compared to other people.” She looked down at the sword being offered to her. “How do you know you can trust me?”

“I don’t. But I hope I can.”

Hope. People had always said they’d hoped she could do better. Adora, Shadow Weaver, all the force captains who trained them over the years. Adora was probably the only one who meant it. Glimmer didn’t know anything about her, and yet she still held hope in her. Not to improve, but that she was already good enough.

She took the weapon, gripping it tight. Maybe, just this once, she *could* be better.

She whispered the nonsensical words burned in her mind, “For the Honor of Grayskull.”

After that was a blur of magic and an eerie calm. Her body seemed to move on its own, swiftly cutting through tanks and chasing off soldiers.

Screams pierced through the serene silence, causing her to stumble. Just like that, the feeling shattered. She collapsed into the dirt as her transformation faded away.

She lifted her head up and in the smoke she met a pair of terrified, blue eyes.

“Adora?”, she tried to call out, but it only came out as a raspy whisper.

Adora backed up in fear, fumbling for her comm. “Retreat to the nearest outpost.”, she spoke into it. With one last look at Catra,

she disappeared.

She let out a noise of surprise when Sparkles latched onto her side. “You did it!”, she exclaimed, “You saved us. You saved everyone.”

Catra laughed breathlessly. “Yeah, I went against the Horde.” Realization struck her. “Oh fuck, I went against the Horde! They’ll kill me if I get caught, what am I supposed to do---”

“Hey hey, it’s ok.”, Sparkles interrupted, “You’re with us now.” She stood up and held out a hand. “Come on. Let’s go home.”

With a bit of hesitation, she took it. A foolish, childish, *hopeful* part of her mind wondered if this would be a new beginning.

Hey Mom I Found a Magical Girl in the Woods, Can I Keep Her?

Chapter Notes

Angella: I just-I have no words
Glimmer: Despite having no words, she proceeded to yell at me for the next 25 mins

Also I stole a line and some aspects from You Came Back (For Me?) by genVicron

WARNING: Implied child abuse and maybe a panic attack? I'm not sure if it's a panic attack but it might be so

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Welcome to Bright Moon." At Sparkles' words, Catra looked up. Built into the cliffside was a castle, shining in the late morning light.

Sparkles turned to Arrow. "You should probably take Catra the back way while I deal with my mom."

"What's the back way?", she asked.

Next thing she knew, she was climbing up a shear wall. " *This* is the back way?" "I know it's not the safest, but it's the only one Queen Angella hasn't found. I think.", Arrow replied as he pulled her up.

She landed in the room and looked around. It seemed a bit like the personal room Force Captains got. It was probably Sparkles'.

It wasn't till she was actually inside that the events of the past few hours caught up to her.

She had left the Horde. She'd fantasized about leaving before. No boring routine, no competition, no Shadow Weaver.

Every time she thought about it, she had imagined Adora being with her, just making their own life together. Never had it crossed her mind to join the rebellion.

Or that Adora would choose the Horde over her.

The silence she and Arrow had fallen into was eventually broken by Sparkles appearing in the room. “I’m here! So my mom’s on her way, but no one panic.”

She turned to Catra. “Don’t worry, she’ll love you. All you have to do is transform into She-ra before she gets here.”

“Wait, we’re jumping straight to She-ra?”, Arrow interjected.

“Yeah, I’m with Arrow boy.”, Catra added, “Lying doesn’t seem like a great idea.” “Well, we’re not *lying* .”, Sparkles argued, “Just not telling her everything till later.”

Catra face palmed.

“Hey, you’re gonna do great.”, Sparkles encouraged, “Bow and I will buy you a bit of time. Just hang out here and think She-ra thoughts.”

She grabbed Arrow. “I believe in you!” With that, they teleported away.

Catra sighed. There was no way she was going with this plan.

She could probably just leave. Run off to the farthest corner of Etheria, forget about the Horde, the Rebellion, the war.

Forget about Adora.

She sighed again and looked down at the sword. It felt good in her grip, knowing that it was *hers* . That it made her worth something.

Worth something to the rebellion at least. But still, it was nice having that magic at her fingertips. Like she could do anything.

She got up and left the room, leaning up against the door. She didn't have anything Horde identifiable on her so she probably wouldn't get in too much trouble if she got caught.

She waited for a few minutes until it sounded like Arrow and Sparkles were coming back, a third person who was probably the queen with them. "Bow, can you make sure that our surprise is ready for us?", she heard Sparkles ask. A second later, Arrow rounded the corner, obviously shocked that she was standing in the hall and not transformed. "What are you doing?", he said in a barely contained whisper.

"I told you, I'm not lying.", she hissed back, "Lying to authority never works out." They'd always catch you.

Arrow sighed, apparently learning quickly that he wasn't going to sway her. He turned back around the corner and told them that she was ready.

The queen was much taller than expected. Catra stood there, waiting for some kind of address.

"Who is this?", the queen asked Sparkles. Sparkles went to stand beside Catra.

"Mom, this is Catra. Who is not going with the plan we agreed on.", she grit out the last part. "Your plan was stupid.", she replied bluntly. Sparkles continued. "She was a Horde soldier--"

"A *Horde soldier* ?" Catra stiffened at the queen's yell, but the anger wasn't towards her. It was towards Glimmer.

"You brought a Horde soldier into Bright Moon without telling me?" "Wait let me explain--" "How could you possibly think this was acceptable?"

Catra took a step back, fear spiking through her chest. She knew what this would lead to. The queen was probably even more powerful than Shadow Weaver, how much could she--

Bow put a hand on her shoulder. “Are you ok?”

She couldn’t answer. She couldn’t breath. She should’ve known the rebellion would be no better than the Horde. Just because they were fighting each other didn’t mean one was good and one was bad.

She gripped the sword tighter. The running away plan sounded very good right now.

“Will you please just listen to me?”, Glimmer shouted over her mother, “I’m *trying* to explain.” The queen gave an irate sigh. “Why have you brought an enemy into Bright Moon?”

Glimmer proceeded to tell the tale Catra still couldn’t quite believe, Bow adding his own confirmation. When she was finished, the queen faced Catra. “Is this true?”, she asked.

“I--Yes.”, Catra replied, almost forgetting words.

The queen looked at the sword still clutched close to her. “I’ve heard the legends of the warrior She-ra. It was said she’d return to us in the hour of our greatest need. I never thought she was anything more than a myth.”

She met Catra’s eyes. “Would you pledge to go against those you once served?”

She straightened and nodded. She didn’t have many other places to go.

“Then the Rebellion accepts your allegiance, She-ra, Princess of Power.”

Sparkles squealed and teleported over to her. “Welcome to Bright Moon!”

And then they kept on moving with the day. Like nothing even happened. The two showed her around the castle as if nothing was wrong.

Arrow broke off at one point, leaving Sparkles to lead Catra to her room.

“What’s going to happen to you?”, she asked. Glimmer looked over to her, confused. “What do you mean?”

“You went behind the queen’s back and brought in a Horde soldier, what’s she going to do to you?”

In response, she simply waved her hand. “Oh you know, I’ll be grounded for a month like usual.”

“Is that getting buried till you learn your lesson?”

“No! I just won’t be able to leave the castle grounds without permission. It sucks.”

Catra frowned at that. It hardly seemed like a punishment. Maybe Bright Moon would be better than the Fright Zone…

Or maybe Glimmer was lying. Catra wasn’t willing to find out herself.

They arrived at her room, a pair of guards standing by the door. Sparkles paid them no mind as they entered a huge space. She casually showed all the crazy things in the room, finishing with "I'm right down the hall if you need anything." and teleporting away.

This was so much different from the Fright Zone.

Which was probably why she struggled so much to sleep.

She was used to the ambient noise of bots, people on the night shift mumbling, and Adora’s breathing. The only thing she had

here was the trickling waterfall and the guards shifting outside her room.

With a grumble, she rolled out of bed and walked over to the window. Balancing on the sill, she jumped out, catching the edge of a hallway window. She repeated this till she felt she was far enough from her room, and climbed out into the hall.

Despite the inordinate amount of empty space, she didn't notice the queen until she bumped into her.

Her first instinct was to salute, but she quickly traded it for a bow she'd seen some of the guards do. "Sorry, your majesty."

"No no, you're alright.", she simply waved off, not even questioning Catra before going back to looking at the mural.

"Who's that?", she asked, deciding to push her luck.

"King Micah. My husband.", the queen answered, "He built the Rebellion with me. He died by the Horde many years ago."

"Oh."

Catra didn't know this man, nor the queen. She had no reason to feel bad. So why did she? If being a good guy came with emotions, she really hated being one.

The queen turned to her. "Glimmer believes you can help us. I love my daughter dearly, so I am willing to give you a chance. I ask you not to disappoint her."

With that, she walked away, leaving Catra alone.

With Shadow Weaver, Catra knew exactly what made her angry. And what kind of punishment would follow. The queen was completely new ground. She'd have to learn quickly.

Glimmer started her day with screaming.

Catra, instead of giving her an answer as to why the fuck she had been sleeping in her room, back flipped off the bed and stiffly walked out the door.

A beautiful morning.

The Rebellion meeting was pretty much first thing, and Glimmer led Catra to the room. “That’s a lot of chairs.”, Catra commented. “They were for the other princesses.”, she explained, “But you know, the alliance fell apart and all.”

She took one of the chairs and Catra sat next to her. “How big *is* the Rebellion?”

“Well, there’s me, my mom, Bow, Bright Moon’s army, Spinerella and Netossa, and now you.”

“That’s not much…”

Their conversation was cut off by her mom entering and taking her place. The meeting started, consisting of a report from General Juliet of a blockade on Plumeria.

Glimmer suggested fighting them off, but apparently her mom liked any plan that wasn’t hers and agreed to Catra’s idea of sending their trio to deliver supplies.

At noon they set off for Plumeria. The closer they got, the more lifeless the foliage was. Despite that, there was plenty of pollen in the air.

“That’s your sneeze?”, Bow exclaimed at Catra’s action.

“What? It’s a normal sneeze.”

“It’s so cute!”

“No it’s not!”

She sneezed again.

“Aaww.”

“I’m gonna turn all your crop tops into regular shirts.”

Bow gasped, seeming genuinely hurt by that.

“Guys, focus.”, Glimmer called back, “We’re almost in Plumeria and we still haven’t seen any sign of the Horde.”

“Would that be a sign?”

She looked to where Bow was pointing to see a plume of smoke rising above the trees. “Yeah that’s probably it.”, Catra confirmed, “There’s only one though…”

“You’re here!” They turned to see Princess Perfuma gliding towards them. Her introduction included getting flower crowns. Catra seemed a bit freaked out from having a flower on her head .

While she was having her crisis, Glimmer spoke. “We’ve come to help with the Horde blockade. We brought food and supplies for you.”

“We appreciate your help very much.”, Perfuma replied, “Come with me, I’ll show you around.”

They passed out supplies during the tour, Perfuma pointing out each special place. Glimmer’s eyes kept flicking towards the smoke trail.

“And this is the Heart Blossom. The center of our kingdom and the source of my magical powers.” Glimmer looked up at the tree. And up. It was huge, its pink leaves painting the sky.

“At least the tree is fine.”, Bow commented, “What happened to everything else?” Perfuma’s smile became strained. “We’re going through a bit of a rough patch, but I’m sure the universe will right itself soon.”

“Everything is dead or dying.”

“Look, the blight hit right after the Horde showed up.”, her smile dropped as she explained, “We don’t know why or how, and nothing I do stops it.”

She shook herself, putting back on the bright exterior. “But we don’t dwell on the negatives. The Heart Blossom is still healthy and that’s what matters.”

“So what’s your plan then?” Perfuma turned to Catra. “Hm?”

“You know, to fight the Horde? That’s right on your doorstep?”

“Plumeria is a peaceful kingdom, our people aren’t fighters. We have to trust that the universe will balance itself and repay the Horde for what it’s done.”

“Why wait for the universe when you can just do it yourselves?”

Catra didn’t give her a chance to reply and stalked off. Glimmer and Bow stuck by Perfuma a bit longer and finished handing out supplies.

They started to make preparations to head back to Bright Moon. Catra didn’t return.

She teleported around, calling out. “Catra! We’re going back to Bright Moon soon, where--” She was cut off by a blur tackling her to the ground.

She thrashed around before a familiar voice hissed. “Sparkles calm down, it’s me.”

“What the fuck, Catra!?”, she demanded, though it was muffled by said girl’s hand. She shushed her and pointed out beyond the edge of the woods that Glimmer hadn’t even realized she’d arrived at.

A horde camp wasn’t very far.

“I don’t think they can hear us from here.”, she reasoned, but kept her voice low. Catra let off her hold and scaled a tree. Glimmer teleported next to her.

“Is this a part of the blockade?”

“There isn’t a blockade.”

Glimmer sent her a confused look. “This is the only camp around here.”, Catra elaborated, “And there aren’t any patrols keeping people from moving in or out.”

“Then what are they up to?”

“I think they’re trying to drive the people out. And if they do that…”

“They’ll have control of a runestone.”, Glimmer finished, horrified, “We have to do something.” She made a move forward, but Catra pulled her back.

“Didn’t Queen Angella specifically tell us *not* to fight the horde?”

“We can’t just sit here and do nothing!”

Catra sighed and mumbled something. “I’m not going to convince you otherwise, am I?” “Nope!”

“Fine.” Her eyes flicked over the base again and she pointed to the building smoke was pouring out of. “That one’s probably important. Think you can get us inside?”

She answered that by grabbing her and teleporting them to the building that was thankfully empty of people.

It did, however, have a large machine pumping a substance into the ground. Catra trailed her hand over it. “This must be what’s killing the plants.”

“So what do we do with it?”

Catra turned to her with a feral grin. “Tear it to shreds.”

“What did you do?”, Bow shouted, having found Glimmer and Catra amongst the chaos. He wasn’t sure if the fires were because of them or Perfuma.

“In my defense, I was left unsupervised.”, Glimmer said.

“You were with Catra!”

“In my defense, I was also left unsupervised.”, she piped in.

“So what made Flower Power change her mind?” “I actually don’t know.”

Bow shot the guy coming up behind him, pinning them to a wall. Glimmer punched back the one going for his left. Then she perked up. “There’s something you should look at.” She grabbed him and teleported him into a building with a broken down machine.

“This is what’s been killing all the plants.”, Glimmer explained, “Catra and I shut it off, but we don’t know how to reverse it. Think you can figure something out?”

He shrugged. “I can try.”

“Great.” With that, she teleported away to join back into the fight. As he examined the machine, the sounds outside died down. Soon Glimmer, Perfuma, and She-ra entered. “Anything?”, Glimmer asked.

He shook his head. “I don’t think it’s reversible. Not with the machine, anyway. There might be an antidote, but I doubt the Horde has it here.”

Glimmer turned to Perfuma. “What about you? You have a connection to all the plants, so maybe now that you’re at the source you could heal them.”

“I might, but…”, she looked up at Catra, “The stories say that the She-ra could heal. Could you do that?”

“I don’t know how.”, she replied.

“Just because you don’t know how, doesn’t mean you don’t have the ability to.” Perfuma led her over the machine, them both crouching down. She placed a hand on the ground and Catra followed.

“Do you feel anything?”

“...No.”

“Look deeper. Magic is in everything, you need to let it flow with your own.”

Bow would never understand magic stuff. Not even after being friends with Glimmer for years. So it was always a bit odd seeing this from an outside point of view.

Then they both started to glow. She-ra especially, her hair flowing in an invisible wind and both her eyes turning gold as they had been in Thaymor.

A wave of magic was sent out and he could *feel* it. Glimmer gasped beside him, her eyes sparkling slightly. They rushed out the building to see the place bursting with life. The swell of magic died down and they turned to look at the other princesses.

Perfuma looked rejuvenated while Catra was exhausted, her transformation having faded away. “Thank you so much.”, Perfuma addressed the three of them, “How can I ever repay you?”

“Join the Rebellion and help me reform the Princess Alliance.”, Glimmer immediately jumped to suggest.

“Um, are you sure? Didn’t that go horribly the first time?”

"It went horribly for our parents, but we have a chance to do it right. You and She-ra were able to heal an entire kingdom! Think of what we could do if we were *all* united."

Perfuma thought for a moment. "Would I get to hit more people with flowers?"

"Absolutely."

"Then you have a deal!" She ran out to the middle of the camp and yelled, "Hey everyone, look at us! We're mighty rebels now!" The people's cheers followed.

Well, that went much better than expected. Even if the queen did ground them all. But that just gave him and Glimmer a great idea.

The moon had set by the time they got back to Bright Moon and given the report on Plumeria. Catra had been preparing herself for whatever punishment would come with disobeying orders, but they were all just grounded.

Maybe the queen was being lenient since they made progress on their mission.

Now all she wanted to do was sleep. Whatever she'd done in Plumeria drained her almost completely. She walked up to her strangely unguarded door and could hear Arrow and Sparkles talking on the other side.

"Hey, there aren't any guards--", she started as she walked in, and then paused, "What are you doing?"

"We're having a sleepover!", Arrow cheered, "And Glimmer convinced her mom to call off the guards."

"Not like they were stopping you, anyway.", she piped in, "Since I found you sleeping in my room this morning."

Catra felt her cheeks heat up and looked away. She'd been banking on the hope she'd wake up before Glimmer and it had failed.

She sat down on the floor with them and Arrow immediately gathered them both in a hug.

"Best Friend Squad!"

"Nope, no, absolutely not."

She was just in the Rebellion because she had nowhere else to go. She'd never call these two her friends.

Catra fell asleep within the hour, laying on the floor in an extra sleeping bag they'd grabbed because the bed was "unnecessarily soft" . Bow and Glimmer laid in their own sleeping bags, having gone quiet a while ago.

"Do you think she doesn't like sleeping alone?", Glimmer whispered out of the blue. Bow looked over to her and she continued. "I mean, I don't know how the Horde works, but it probably has a lot more people than Bright Moon."

Bow hummed in response. "Well, if she doesn't like being alone, we'll always be with her. The Best Friend Squad's gotta stick together."

It's what friends do.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter is shit but whatever

Don't expect another one soon, I do have the next chapter written out but I'm not all that happy with it so it'll probably be a few weeks

Seas the Day

Chapter Notes

> Remember how I said it'd probably be a few weeks? So it turns out I'm a liar
>
> The next one probably will be a couple weeks tho cuz I'm not finished with it

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora stepped into the Black Garnet chamber, her hair immediately standing on end. She didn't ponder if it was from the electricity or something else. "You wanted to see me?"

Shadow Weaver motioned her to stand next to her. A screen flicked on in front of them. Adora gasped quietly when it showed Catra fighting against Horde soldiers, the princess not far away.

"This was brought to me a few days ago by retreating soldiers. Retreating because their camp was attacked by Catra," the footage switched, "And She-ra."

Shadow Weaver looked down at her. "Were you planning on telling me this?"

"It's not her fault.", Adora immediately defended, "The princesses they--they brainwashed her and turned her into a weapon. I swear I was going to tell you--" Shadow Weaver held up a hand and she cut herself off.

"Adora,", she started, her voice taking on a warm tone, "I do wish you had trusted me with this sooner." She glided over to the stand, swirling the water inside of it.

"I sent my shadow spies out to keep an eye on her. They tell me she is in Seaworthy and is heading towards Salineas."

Adora straightened. “When do I leave?”

“You won’t be going alone. Force Captain Scorpia will join you. She will make sure your...affections don’t get in the way.”

Adora relaxed slightly. Scorpia was nice, if a bit inattentive. She could’ve been paired with worse.

“A boat is being prepared.”, Shadow Weaver continued, “She will be waiting there for you. It would be best not to keep her waiting.”

With a nod Adora left the chamber, ready to save her best friend.

They stepped into the building, the smell of alcohol hitting Glimmer’s nose. Raucous laughter filled the air.

Bow practically had stars in his eyes. “Seaworthy is just like I imagined it. Everyone here looks like a real pirate!”

“Focus, we’re here to find a sea captain.”

“No pirates?”

“No pirates.”

Ignoring Bow’s disappointed “Arrr”, she walked up to the bar. “Excuse me,”, she started, “We’re looking for a sea captain?”

The woman looked down at her, eyeing her for a moment, then pointed to the far corner of the room where it seemed a wrestling match was taking place.

The loser walked away and the trio stepped up to the winner. “Hi, we were told you were a sea captain?”

The man chuckled. “I am the one and only Seahawk!”, he jumped onto the table with a yell, “Has my reputation preceded me?”

Catra didn’t seem impressed, while Bow was quite the opposite.

Glimmer sat across from Seahawk who followed. “Captain Seahawk, we’re interviewing captains to take us to Salineas. Would you like to apply for the position?”

He laughed again. “Apply for the position? I am the one and only Seahawk, I’m offer only.”

“That doesn’t tell us if you’re actually qualified.”, Catra pointed out. He laughed *again* , and rattled off some of his accomplishments. If Bow hadn’t been in awe before, he was now. “You’re hired!”, he declared.

Glimmer elbowed him.

“What makes you think you can afford me?”

“I assure you, money is no object.”

He pulled a paper from his shirt (the fuck???) and held it out. “Behold, my fee.” She gingerly took it.

Oh. That was a lot of money.

Catra scoffed. “Please, this guy is all talk. I bet we wouldn’t last five minutes with him.”

Seahawk huffed in offense. “You wouldn’t find another soul who knows the treacherous route to Salineas like I do. I use it often to visit my close, personal friend, Princess Mermista.”

Catra put her hand on the table and leaned closer in challenge. “So you could get us to Salineas in a day?”

“Less than!”

“Then prove it.”

Seahawk leapt up. “I shall! Forward to adventure!”

“What was that?”, Glimmer hissed as they were led to the docks. Catra smirked in reply.

“ *That* , was me getting us a sea captain.”

Adora looked over the edge of the boat, the water churning below her, sea spray misting her face. She was silent in thought. There was one thing about this whole situation still bothering her.

Why Catra?

She wasn’t well known or high ranking, and there was no way the Rebellion knew Adora was a Force Captain and would try to use Catra against her.

Maybe it had been random. They needed someone to test the weapon on and it just so happened to be Catra that they took.

She couldn’t tell if it was better or worse the Rebellion didn’t decide to test it out on one of their own people.

Scorpia rambled something beside her and Adora gave a noncommittal hum in response. She looked down at her, concerned.

“Hey, you ok?”

“What? Yeah, I’m fine.”

Scorpia didn’t seem convinced.

“Are you seasick? Ah, I probably should’ve asked before we got on a boat.” Next thing Adora knew, she was being held in Scorpia’s arms. “Now just focus on me, ok? It’ll help.”

This gave Adora feelings. She wasn’t sure if she disliked these feelings.

“Uh, Captain?”, Kyle interrupted. His eyes flicked between them, but he didn’t comment. “We’re getting close to the Sea Gate. We won’t be able to get through.”

They both turned their heads to see that sure enough, the Sea Gate wasn’t far from them. Adora squinted at the golden glow coming from a platform on the gate. She wriggled herself out of Scorpia’s grip and took the binoculars Kyle had been using.

She could make out She-ra, the archer, and an unfamiliar member. She-ra was holding her sword out to the gate, light pouring out of it.

“That’s fine, we don’t need to get through. We just need to get Catra.” She stood straighter and turned to her team.

“Kyle, keep on watch, Rolegio, keep us moving forward, and Lonnie, ready the cannon.”

“Ooh, impressive Captain Yell.”, Scorpia complimented.

“Thanks!”

At her command, Lonnie fired the cannon just below the platform. “Uh, captain. I think they’ve spotted us.”, Kyle reported.

“Good.”, Adora replied.

“Uh, the princess is there, and She-ra--” He was interrupted by a chime as the two appeared on the ship.

“Hey Adora.”, Catra grinned.

The rest of her team went for the princess and Catra lept in front of her. “Catra, I don’t want to fight you.”

“Yeah, me neither. But I’m trying to fix that gate and it’s a bit hard when we’re being shot at.”

“I’ll call it off. We’re just here to bring you home.”

Catra's eyes narrowed at that. "I'm not going back."

"This isn't you talking, it's just whatever the rebellion has done to you."

That seemed to set something off.

She-ra launched forward and Adora whipped out her baton to block. Her momentum sent them somersaulting across the deck. Adora wrestled herself on top of her, but this only gave She-ra an opening to kick her off, launching her away. She quickly recovered and moved back to the offensive.

Aside from stumbling every so often, She-ra fought exactly like Catra. It was eerie.

Adora's swing was dodged, answered with a swipe she ducked under. They kept up this dance until She-ra got a grip on her staff, pulling them nearly face to face. She smirked and then kneed her in the gut.

Adora stumbled back, bumping into the railing. She-ra leapt for her again, causing her to lean over the bow as she was pinned against it.

She looked back up at her, hoping that somewhere, somehow, Catra was just waiting to break through.

"Please, I want to help you."

She-ra pushed back harder. "I don't *need* you to help me, I don't *need* you to protect me. I can take care of myself."

Her eyes glanced over the edge. Instead of shoving her off, she stepped back and ran for the cannon. With a yell, she smashed into it with her sword, the entire thing fizzling out.

"Hey Sparkles, I think it's time to make our escape." Before anyone could do anything, the princess teleported them both away.

Adora was so caught up in searching for them, she didn’t notice the on fire boat until it came crashing into them.

An hour later, she was back in the Fright Zone, washing the sea water out of her hair. She collapsed onto her bed, exhausted.

There was a knock on her door. Reluctantly, she got back up and answered. “Oh, hey Scorpia.”, Adora said, “What are you doing here?”

“I wanted to check up on how you were doing, you know, with the failed mission and all.”, she replied.

Adora blinked. She hadn’t expected Scorpia to care. They hadn’t even met before Force Captain Orientation and she'd only been assigned to go with her to Salineas. There wasn’t any reason for her to be here now.

But, it felt nice. Knowing someone cared. “I’m fine.”, she assured, “It was just one mission, I’ll have more chances.”

Catra was still in there. She knew she was, why else would She-ra have spared her?

She just needed to figure out a way to break through. She could fix this.

She had to.

Chapter End Notes

> If there's anything reading through the transcript has taught me, it's the insane amount of times these characters say each other's names

Calm Before the Storm

Chapter Notes

> Hi and welcome back to Piece of Shit! Today's chapter: A Piece of Shit!
>
> Yeah so I didn't have much to add to System Failure and Mystacor is getting moved to later, but I didn't want to jump straight to Princess Prom. But I also can't write casual fluff for the life of me so instead you get an attempt

“Let me see what you have!”

“A knife!”

“NO!”

“Oh, she found a knife?”

Ignoring Entrapta’s comment, Glimmer ran after Catra. Whatever that robot virus had done to her made it infinitely harder to navigate the maze.

When would she be released from this torture?

After gaining Entrapta as a member of the alliance, there were no more missions for their group to be a part of. Princess Frosta would be good to talk to next, but Princess Prom was coming up and would be hosted in her kingdom. That would be a better time.

Until then, the trio would be able to relax in Bright Moon.

“So I can either bake these cookies at four hundred degrees for ten minutes, or four *thousand* degrees for one minute?”

“Catra, no, that’s not how you make cookies.”

Glimmer popped up next to her. “Floor it?”

Bow’s panic increased. “Guys, no!”

A feral grin spread across Catra’s face. “How about four million degrees for one second!”

“You’re going to burn this castle down!”

“We’re going to harness the power of all the fucking moons to make cookies!”, Glimmer cheered.

“GUYS, PLEASE!”

Fortunately, they didn’t burn anything because one of the chefs heard their shouting and kicked them out of the kitchens.

“Well, there goes making cookies.”, Glimmer grumbled.

“I wouldn’t have been able to eat them anyway.”, Catra shrugged. Bow turned to her. “Why not?”

“I can’t eat chocolate.”

“How do you know that?”, Glimmer asked, “Wasn’t the only food in the Horde ‘ration bars’ or something?”

“Yeah, but sometimes people would bring back sweets and stuff. A few would give the younger cadets some of it.”

She remembered it well. Shadow Weaver would never let them have any of the sweets. But Catra had managed to steal some of the chocolate for her and Adora. She’d gotten sick afterwards while Adora was buzzing pretty much all day.

She quickly brushed off the thought of Adora. It had been clear from the beginning which side she’d pick. They were enemies now and she had no reason to be thinking of her like that anymore.

And with the alliance coming back together, Catra felt less like she was in a losing fight.

It had been a little over a week since the failed mission in Salineas. Nothing had happened since then, so Adora continued getting used to the new routine that came with being a Force Captain. Which mainly consisted of training some of the young cadets and wandering the halls.

Most would've found it boring, but for her it was extremely nerve wracking. Every second spent in the Fright Zone doing nothing was another second Catra was trapped with the Rebellion.

But she hadn't been assigned anymore missions, and she couldn't just go out and get Catra back on her own….Could she?

It would be a good idea. Taking the initiative instead of waiting for orders would save her sooner, and quell her need to go out there and *do* something. Shadow Weaver would most likely be angry with her, but it was worth it for Catra, wasn't it?

Half an hour later, she was pacing in her room.

"Ok, this might get us in a lot of trouble, but...I think we should make our own plan to get back Catra.", Adora started, "We can't break through the spell on our own, so our best bet is to capture her and take her back to the Fright Zone so Shadow Weaver can do it. But she's good at getting out of tight situations, and she's always with the princess--", she stopped, "That's it! If we capture the *princess* then they'll send She-ra after her and we'll have Catra *and* a princess!"

And maybe Shadow Weaver would be less mad at her.

She took a breath. "Thanks for helping me, Scorpia, I really appreciate it." Said girl jerked her head up. "What? Oh yeah, not a problem."

“Now we just got to figure out how to capture her…”

“Why don’t you try something at the All-Princess Ball? Every princess is gonna be there.” Adora looked over to see Scorpia reading over a scroll. “Ooh, this year’s theme is Winter Wonderland!”

“Where did you get that?”, Adora asked, jumping down next to her to look over the scroll herself.

“They sent it to me. I’m a princess, remember?”

Oh right. It was so easy to forget that when Scorpia was so nice.

“They sent you an invite?”

“Yeah, every princess gets one. I think it’s supposed to promote peace or something? I’m not really sure, my family didn’t go to them for a while.”

“Why not?”

Scorpia sighed and looked away. “My family never really...fit with the other kingdoms. We made them uncomfortable and the other princesses didn’t like that. They didn’t like me.”

Adora bumped their shoulders together. “Why should you care about what the *princesses* think? You should go if you want to.” Scorpia looked down at her. “You really think so?”

“Sure! You’re right, it would be a good place to at least try a plan, and if we’re gonna be sneaking out, you deserve to do something you want.”

Scorpia grinned, raising a claw into the air and whooping, “Super Pal Duo is going to Prom!”

She had know idea when Scorpia has given them that name, but ok.

You Can Dance If You Wanna, You Can Leave Your Friends Behind

Chapter Notes

> Me: Hey, I'm almost done with this chapter! All I gotta do is figure out one last conversation--
> Brain: Redo the entire thing
> Me: What
> Brain: DO IT
>
> I think it came out better in the end anyway so thank you brain for once
>
> But I did kinda ignore the timeline of the episode so that might seem a little confusing

Before joining the Rebellion, Catra hadn't even *heard* of snow. Well, she had from some other kids who had been brought in from the north, but she didn't believe them.

Now that she was experiencing it, she could confidently say she hated snow more than Shadow Weaver. And that was a high bar to reach.

From what Arrow had described of parties, she'd been expecting something a lot more exciting. Instead it was cold, wet, and boring.

Most of the royalty was stuffy and talked amongst themselves, Frosta brushed off her attempt to convince her into the Princess Alliance completely, and Sparkles was moping about Arrow.

All in all a horrible time.

Despite how much she'd rather hide off in her own corner or just leave, Catra found herself next to Sparkles again.

“Where have you been?”, she asked. “Getting told off by a ten year old.”, she replied. Sparkles didn’t say anything about the probably disrespectful comment. Instead she went back leaning on the banister, sighing forlornly.

Catra looked over the railing and rolled her eyes when she saw Arrow and Perfuma in her line of sight. “Quit moping about it.”

“I’m not moping!”, Sparkles protested, “Bow can hang out with whoever he wants, and we see each other all the time anyway, it’s fine. It’s fine.” Catra simply raised her eyebrow, unconvinced.

“Look, it’s always just been me and Bow, ok?”, she defended, “But now what if he likes Perfuma better than me? What if everyone does?” Catra chose to ignore how close to home those words hit. It wasn’t important.

“Arrow isn’t gonna leave you behind for a new friend, there’s no reason to be--”

She cut herself off when a familiar blonde walked through the door, arm in arm with the scorpion Force Captain. A burning feeling rose up.

“...Jealous.”

She narrowed her eyes, watching them greet Frosta and *not* get themselves immediately kicked out. She nudged Sparkles. “You might wanna brush me up on the rules again, cause’ I’m pretty sure they’re not allowed here.”

Sparkles looked over to where she was pointing. Her eyes bulged. “How the fuck did they get in here?”, she nearly shouted, standing up.

“Oh, that must be Princess Scorpia. The blonde is most likely her plus one.”

The two jumped in surprise, turning to see Entrapta behind them. They glanced at each other, then back at Entrapta. “How do you

know that?", Catra asked.

"I like to do some light research on each kingdom before every Princess Prom. Scorpia's kingdom was where the Fright Zone is currently located, it was taken quite a while ago."

"And they *invited her* ?", Sparkles asked incredulously.

Entrapta nodded. "Yep. Every princess gets an invitation, no matter what wars or disputes are happening."

Catra faced back to the ballroom, spotting Scorpia and Adora talking amongst themselves by the food table. Or maybe they were just enjoying the fact they had real food here.

Adora was up to something. She wouldn't have come to a *princess* ball for no reason.

She hopped over the railing, ignoring any looks it might've gotten her, and weaved her way through the crowd towards the two. She caught the end of their conversation.

"...Make sure to keep her attention on you long enough to lead her away." Scorpia answered with a salute and a "Yes ma'am!", and walked off.

Good.

"Hey Adora."

Said girl jumped, looking over to her. "Catra, what are you doing here?" "Apparently I'm an *honorary princess* now.", she answered, "But the real question is what are *you* doing here?"

Adora held her chin up slightly. "I'm Scorpia's plus one." The seeming proudness in that statement caused jealousy to burn in her chest. She knew it was jealousy, she'd felt it before. She just wasn't sure why she was still feeling it now.

She didn’t let her emotions show, instead giving a grin. “How long did you spend analyzing the invite?”

“...Six hours.”

She laughed, and for a moment it felt like nothing changed. It was just the two of them talking and teasing each other. Reality registered again and she stopped, letting her smile drop.

“Ok, let’s cut to the chase. What are you planning?” Adora looked away.

“I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

“You’ve always been a shitty liar. I know you wouldn’t come here just to have a good time.”

“Well maybe you don’t know me as well as you thought you did.”, Adora huffed.

“Please, we grew up together. No one knows you better than me.”

“At least they let you keep your memories.”, she mumbled. Catra growled in frustration. “Do you seriously still think I’m being mind controlled? The princesses can’t even do that!”

“How do I know that isn’t just the mind control talking?”

“The only powers the queen and princess of Bright Moon have are *glitter* . The other princesses powers are just as frilly and simple.”

“You don’t know that! Why would they tell someone they kidnapped all about they’re abilities?”

“For fucks sake, Adora! I wasn’t kidnapped, I wasn’t brainwashed, I left on my own!”, Catra yelled, “Did you really not notice your skiff keys were missing?”

Adora flinched back at that, staring at her in shock. Almost looking hurt.

Suddenly, the lights cut out, causing them to look up. More dim, colorful lights soon took their place. Frosta's voice carried over the ballroom. "It is my solemn duty as hostess to announce the first dance of the ball."

They were swept up in the crowd as everyone took their place on the floor. They stood to find they were the only ones without partners. Reluctantly, Catra held up her hand and Adora took it. Music started up.

They danced silently, Adora not even willing to look her in the eye. Catra nearly sighed in relief when they spun away from each other and she was met with Bow.

"Do you know where Glimmer is?", he asked, "We kinda got into a fight earlier and she ran off."

She shrugged. "I don't know, I haven't seen her."

They spun away again, this time her partner being Perfuma.

"Hey, have you seen Sparkles?"

"Oh, I saw her go outside, but that was a little while ago.", she replied, then added on almost absent mindedly, "The Horde princess left around the same time too."

They separated to new partners as it clicked. Catra was again met with Adora.

She should jump on her right now and demand to know what they did with Glimmer. But she'd get thrown out in a heartbeat. Instead, she spoke through gritted teeth. "Where's Glimmer?"

Adora's lips quirked, like she wanted to smirk. Like she'd won a game Catra didn't know they were playing.

"I have no idea what you're talking about."

“You’re alone and outnumbered. It’s a losing fight. Just admit to it.”

Adora dropped her hand and stepped back. “I may be outnumbered, but I am not alone.”

The bombs went off.

The building shook, people crying out and scattering. Debris began to fall from the ceiling. Adora was already running.

Catra turned to Bow. “Scorpia has Glimmer, go find them!” With a nod, he ran off, and she began after her own target.

The entrance caved in, trapping the people inside. Adora broke away from the crowd into a hallway, and Catra chased her down. They reached a dead end. Adora backed up against the wall. “Give it up, you’re trapped.”, Catra bit.

The fallen ice around them started glowing, rising into the air. Adora grabbed onto a chunk, letting it pull her upwards. Catra hopped onto her own platform and soon they were both facing off on the roof.

Catra knew she had the advantage. She had always been faster and had a weapon in the form of claws.

But, as always, she forgot she was second best.

Catra went to jab her elbow into Adora’s side, but she moved at the last moment, sending her flying off the edge. The only reason she didn’t fall was Adora clutching onto her jacket. They stilled, staring at each other as they leaned over the edge of death.

The castle shook beneath them.

Wind whipped in her hair as they tumbled down. Catra swung out wildly, grasping Adora’s hand and digging her claws into the ice. She grinded her teeth in pain as they slowed to a stop.

They dangled there, hundreds of feet from the ground. “Hang on, I can get us out of this.”, she tried to assure, frantically search for any kind of platform they could land on.

Adora’s hand slipped from her grip.

She screamed, watching as she silently vanished into the clouds. Moments later, a ship appeared. It rose up to her eye level and she could see into the cockpit.

Relief washed over her when she saw Adora safe inside. It was replaced with icy, cold dread when she realized Bow and Glimmer were tied up and unconscious in the seat next to her. “If you want your princess back, you’ll have to come to the Fright Zone.”

They flew off, leaving Catra alone above a drop that was as terrifying and unclear as the future.

Intermission: A Simple Zest For Life

Chapter Notes

> I know it's only been 5 days but I'm doing an intermission to say, the next chapter will probably be a while. I got the beginning and end of it down, but the middle's kinda neeeeeeh. Also I've been writing almost constantly for a couple of weeks now and should probably take a break before I burn myself out and loose motivation. So yeah

It was the middle of the night. Glimmer could hear the unmistakable sound of Catra running up and down the hallway. With a groan, she teleported to the noise. “Why do you have to run around at night?”, she complained.

Catra stopped, looking at her with eyes blown wide. In a completely serious tone she replied, “A simple zest for life.”

Glimmer leveled her with a flat look. “Could you get your zesting on at a more reasonable hour?”

“Zest has no curfew!”, she declared as she took off down the hall.

Shadow Weaver Gets Decked

Chapter Notes

Hey bitches what's up

Sorry this took so long, fight scenes are hard. Which is why I kinda skipped over the one I was struggling with

I'm not really happy with this chapter but I don't have any better ideas, so here ya go

Also I forgot to mention last chapter that Adora didn't take the sword. Catra still has it

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra regretted asking Seahawk and Mermista for a ride back to Bright Moon.

They were the first people she'd found that she actually knew, and the flurry of panic going through her made her forget entirely about their mode of transportation.

The fact that every rock of the boat made her uneasy, and that the water below them was miles deep, she didn't have much focus to spare for what she should be doing.

Which was making a plan to rescue Glimmer and Bow.

The one thing she was sure about in this whole situation was that she needed to get them back. They were her--

The boat rocked again and her train of thought cut off. She took a tentative look over the railing, breathing a sigh of relief when she saw trees in the distance. The moment they got to shore, she hopped off. From there to Bright Moon was thankfully only a half hour trip through the Whispering Woods.

They arrived at the castle in the very early morning. Seahawk and Mermista went off to change into different clothes, but Catra didn't bother. She needed to find Angella immediately.

One of the guards told her she was in the war room. She didn't waste a second getting there. She burst through the doors. "Queen Angella, Glimmer and Bow have been--"

"Captured by the Horde, I know.", she sighed, "I just received their message. I've been given a day to surrender myself for her safety."

Catra gaped. "You can't do that, we don't know if the Horde will hold up their end of the deal. If you surrender, *no one* will be safe."

The queen looked up at her. "What other options do we have?" Catra straightened, gathering her thoughts.

"The Horde won't give them back, so we need to *take* them back." She sat down in the seat across from her.

"An invasion is out of the question, we don't have the strength for that. Sneaking in would be better.", she started, "I know almost every inch of the Fright Zone, and the Princess Alliance is a small and strong team. Mermista and Seahawk have already agreed to help, we just need to convince Entrapta and Perfuma."

Angella seemed to be considering it. That filled her with more relief than she expected. "Do we know if they are willing?"

"We are." They turned to the door to see Perfuma and Entrapta, Seahawk and Mermista close behind. Perfuma stepped forward, determined. "We're ready for our first mission."

Catra felt herself relax as everyone took a seat at the table. She pulled up a blank map and started drawing out what she could remember of the Fright Zone.

“I am disappointed in you, Adora. This is the second time you’ve gone outside of the Fright Zone without my permission.”, Shadow Weaver scolded.

“I’m sorry, Shadow Weaver. But nothing was getting done with me just sitting here.”, Adora argued, “I had to do *something* .”

Shadow Weaver hummed in acknowledgment. “I must admit, your actions did prove to be fruitful.”, she replied, gesturing to the unconscious princess.

“I shall alert Hordak of this development.” With that, she glided out of the room, leaving Adora with a slowly waking princess.

She blearily took in her surroundings. When her eyes landed on Adora, her squint hardened into a scowl. “Great. It’s you.”, she grumbled.

Adora didn’t reply. The princess continued. “I bet you’re just *so* proud of yourself.”

She blinked at that. “I mean, yeah, why wouldn’t I be?”

“Because you kidnapped someone!”

Adora straightened, returning the yell. “You kidnapped Catra first!”

“No we didn’t!”

“You really expect me to believe that?”

The princess grit her teeth. She lit up with magic, seeming to phase in and out of being. Whatever she was trying to do was stopped by her restraints. Adora flinched slightly as she cried out in pain.

The magic calmed, and the princess looked up at her. “You can’t keep me here forever. She-ra will come for me.”

"That's what I was hoping for.", Adora replied. She shook herself. She didn't need to be talking to a princess, there wasn't any point. She left the chamber to find something better to occupy her time.

When she came by her room, she stopped.

"Did you really not notice your skiff keys were missing?"

The conversation still nagged at her. But it wasn't true. It couldn't be.

...could it?

She stepped into the room and over to her bag that she hadn't felt the need to fully unpack yet. She emptied out the contents.

The key she'd been given upon becoming a Force Captain was nowhere to be found.

The plan went like this: Angella would teleport them into one the more deserted areas of the Fright Zone, which happened to be close to the cell block. From there it'd be easy to get through the halls, handle any patrols they ran into, find Glimmer and Bow, and get out. It was supposed to be simple.

Keyword being 'supposed'.

They landed in the wrong room, but it was the right area nonetheless. This should've been a sign of how the rest of the plan would go.

As the group entered the hall, Catra realized just how much they stood out in this place. They should've thought to bring something that blended in a bit more.

She took a moment to orient herself, then motioned them to follow her. They walked silently, her having to backtrack a couple times, until they came across a pair of guards. They were at the

entrance of the hall they were currently in, blocking their way to one of the main halls. That would probably lead them to the cell block.

She turned to the group, addressing them in a whisper. “Ok, we need to do this as discreetly as possible--Where’s Entrapta?”

They looked around, finally noticing that one of their members was missing. “How long has she been gone?!”

“I stopped paying attention a few hallways back...”, Mermista trailed off.

Catra took a breath, thinking. “Ok...Perfuma, Angella, you go find Entrapta. If anything happens, get out of the Fright Zone.” She tensed, realizing she was taking the command, when *Angella* was the *queen* --

But Angella nodded along with Perfuma and they left.

Letting go of that brief panic, she turned to Mermista and Seahawk. “Ok, we’ll take out the guards on three. One--”

“FORWARD!”

Seahawk charged out with a yell towards the guards, who immediately turned to the noise. They held up their stun batons, but he didn’t stop running. He ducked under their strike, elbowing one in the gut.

Before the other could shock him in the back, a water pipe burst open, the force slamming them into the wall.

Mermista ran out to properly join the fight, and Catra followed. “What was that?”, she yelled at Seahawk. “I got excited.”, he shrugged.

So much for 'discreetly as possible'.

The guards stood back up, and Mermista brought up the water to knock them back. But one of them dodge, aiming the baton towards her. Catra leapt on their shoulders, sending them flailing to the ground. With a swift knock to the head, she felt their body go limp beneath her.

The other swiped their baton at her. She jumped back, landing a few feet away.

Mermista and Seahawk stood beside her, lifting up their weapons of choice. Catra held up the sword, transformation words on the tip of her tongue. Then a robot walked in.

The guard briefly looked back at it, and Mermista took the opportunity to bang them against the wall one last time. They fell unconscious onto the floor. The group looked up, seeing who was sitting on the robot.

"Hi!", Entrapta waved.

"Where have you been?", Catra hissed. "Oh, I got side tracked when I found Emily here.", she patted the robot she was sitting which made an affectionate trill in response. "Where's Perfuma and Angella?"

"They went to look for you--Nevermind. Let's just get to the cell block."

They stashed the guards in one of the rooms. Even though the area didn't have much activity, the fact that they weren't stationed on a main hall and how much noise they made would go noticed soon. They'd have to be quick.

They waited for a patrol to pass, and entered the cell block. Catra brought up one of the computers and navigated her way to the list of prisoners. There was a surprisingly small amount, so it was easy to find Bow's name. Glimmer's wasn't anywhere on it.

That was a problem they'd have to deal with later. For now they needed to focus on Bow.

She explained this to the others, and she and Seahawk got on one of the walkways, letting Entrapta control. Catra was very much regretting that decision when they shot upwards.

She clutched onto the platform, letting out a screech of terror. She glanced up and made eye contact with someone.

Lonnie.

They came to an abrupt stop just above her. Standing next to her was Rolegio and two others. They stared at each other for a moment before Lonnie leapt onto the platform, pulling out a stun baton. The walkway plummeted downwards.

"Wasn't expecting you to come back.", Lonnie bit.

"You know me. Always full of surprises.", Catra quipped back. She held up the sword and transformed.

It should've been a short fight. It was two against one, and she had She-ra. But Seahawk jumped off to take care of the other two soldiers, and Catra still wasn't quite used to She-ra's size.

She underestimated her momentum, and toppled forward. Lonnie took the opportunity to press the stun baton into her back, sending her to her knees.

"You come all the way back here for people you met, what, three weeks ago?", Lonnie questioned while Catra was still down, "Why do even care that much?"

"Because they're my friends!" The admission was surprisingly easy. Maybe she'd only known them for under a month, maybe she hadn't been entirely open with them, but they had shown her the world in a way she never thought she'd see it. And it was clear they cared about her.

And she cared about them two.

Catra pushed herself back up and the fight resumed.

They didn’t notice a vine attach itself to the ceiling until they heard a shriek and looked over to see Perfuma swinging towards them. She slammed into Lonnie, knocking her over the edge and onto a walkway below.

Perfuma stood up, breathless with exhilaration. “Oh wow!”, she exclaimed, “I’ve never done anything like that before.”

“Where’s Angella?”, Catra asked and her smile fell. “We got separated. She’s probably out of the Fright Zone by now, but I don’t know.”

She felt a spike of dread at that. But Angella was smart enough to know not to stick around even if everyone else was still here. It did mean they’d have to come up with an escape route on the spot, but this entire disasterfuck of a plan seemed to be full of improvisations.

Entrapta finally got control of the platform, lowering them to the right level. They ran up to Bow’s cell, Seahawk throwing aside the person--Wait, shit, was that Kyle? Eh, whatever--standing in front of it.

With a stab to the keyboard, the barrier fizzled out. Bow immediately came running with a hug that was for once met with no struggling. When he pulled back, that starry, overly happy look was in his eyes.

“Catra, did you finally admit that we’re your friends?”

“Stop it right now or I take it all back.”

His second hug only received minimal protest.

When he let go this time, his face was serious. “Glimmer’s in the Black Garnet Chamber. Do you know where that is?”

She sucked in a breath. “Yeah, I’m pretty familiar with that place…”

Then the alarms went off. More than one of them cursed.

Catra gestured to them to follow her, leading them through the halls. There was one way out she knew they wouldn't be easily followed through.

"This vent system leads outside.", she explained as Entrapta opened the doors, "The skiff bay is nearby and easy to get into. The doors won't stay open for long, so you need to hurry."

They started running through, but Bow stopped when she didn't follow. "What are you doing?"

"I still need to find Glimmer. Get out of the Fright Zone and make sure Angella is out too."

He tried to protest, reaching out for her. But she slammed her fist on the keypad and the door closed.

She detransformed and kicked off the wall, clutching onto one of the ceiling vents. She crawled inside, watching the soldiers below her run past.

She made her way through the tunnels, until she reached the grate with red light streaming through. She looked through it into the Black Garnet Chamber. It seemed to be empty, except for Glimmer kneeling on the floor and being kept in place by Shadow Weaver's magic.

She flipped the grate open and dropped silently into the room in front of Glimmer. She lifted her head up, her eyes lighting up when she saw Catra. Then they were filled with fear.

Catra had enough time be confused before a familiar, paralyzing feeling sent her rim rod straight.

Shit.

She was turned to face Shadow Weaver and Adora, whose face was a mixture of relief and concern. Catra would've sent her scowl

if she could *move.*

The shadows swirled around her, strapping her onto a table. Shadow Weaver glided over, looking down at her.

She waved a hand at Adora. “Leave us.” She hesitated, stepping forward and looking at Catra with worry. Shadow Weaver didn’t take kindly to this. The darkness in the room flared. “ *Did you not hear me* ?”

She flinched back, and with a nod, she left.

The magic fell away and Catra jerked her head up, forming the harshest glare she could muster. “What do you want with me?”, she snapped, getting straight to the point, “We both know I’m not important to you.”

“Yes, but no matter how much of a disappointment you are, I must admit you aren’t *entirely* useless.”, Shadow Weaver replied. She took off Catra’s mask, letting it clatter to the floor. “You have been quite good for keeping Adora obedient.”

Not even anything about She-ra or her own abilities. Still just Adora.

Her hands crackled with electricity. “She would be *heartbroken* if I didn’t bring you back as promised.” Catra didn’t bother to try and move away as she reached towards her face. She knew it wouldn’t stop her. “And if some of that flippant personality gets erased along the way, then it truly is a shame the princesses’ magic ran so deep.”

Then there was pain.

This wasn’t the burns or paralyzing she was used to. This was in her *head* . *Under her skin.*

She felt a warmth. Magic, different and much more comforting than the other kind she was feeling at that moment. It wrapped

itself around her, softening the agony of Shadow Weaver digging at her core.

But it couldn't stop the scream ripping from her throat.

Then there was a bright, white light and a yell, and the pain truly stopped. She gasped for air, peaking her eyes open to see Queen Angella standing over an unconscious Shadow Weaver. Glimmer's restraints fizzled out.

She first helped Glimmer stand up, then went to undo the straps around Catra. "Are you alright?", Angella asked softly, and she nodded breathlessly. She slid off the table, wobbling a little as she stood up.

They all froze when they saw Adora standing in the doorway.

Glimmer raised her fists, and Catra unsheathed the sword, but Adora made no move. When it was clear there was no fight to be had, Angella placed a hand on their shoulders and they teleported away.

They appeared in the outskirts of the Fright Zone, and moved quickly into the surrounding desert, finding the group on a skiff hidden beneath an outcropping. Their faces lit up when they saw the three of them. Catra felt her own smile creep onto her face as they made their way over.

But then she noticed someone was missing.

"Where's Entrapta?" Everyone's smiles fell at that.

Chapter End Notes

Is it out of character for Angella to join a mission this early? Probably. Am I too attached to the idea and have it engrained in the plot? Yes

In canon it kinda seemed they kept the plan secret from Angella since they were doing it in Glimmer's room, but I didn't think Catra would feel the need to that. So why not include Angella and let her punch Shadow Weaver?

And I just wanna say that I'm so fucking excited for the next two chapters

Shadows Do Tend to Follow You

Chapter Notes

> Shadow Weaver at Catra: I only electrocuted you a little bit, grow up

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They landed in the safety of the Whispering Woods, stopping to take a breath. They all needed it after everything that happened.

"I can't believe she's really gone…", someone, probably Bow, murmured.

"This only happened because we were together.", Mermista said grimly, "Maybe there's a reason the alliance fell apart before. Maybe this whole thing was a bad idea."

"No."

All heads turned to Angella who had stood up. "You mustn't let one mistake tear you apart."

It was Catra's turn to stand. " *Mistake* ? Entrapta's *dead* and we're supposed to, what, ignore it?"

"No, we will mourn Entrapta, as she deserves. But this war is still going, and you still need each other. We should've kept fighting. And you should too."

No one said anything for a while. They sat there, taking in the silence. It was broken when Glimmer cried out.

She was glowing a familiar, horrifying red.

Catra stood in front of the mirror in the guest room she'd been given. They'd arrived at Mystacor the day before, and she'd spent

most of it sleeping. Angella, Bow, and herself were the only ones who stayed, the others having gone home soon after Glimmer was seen to the care of some healers.

No one said anything more about leaving the alliance. That at least gave her a little hope.

But her current problem was that she looked weird without her mask. She'd had the thing for two or three years, so seeing herself without it was just odd.

She mussed up her hair, trying to get it to frame her face in a similar way the mask did. It didn't stay in place very well, but it'd probably grow into it.

She looked down at her clothes. They were fine, if a little worn, but it would be nice to get something new. She'd already left what little she had in the Horde behind, what was a bit more?

But that would be something to worry about later. When her friend didn't have a magic virus.

Despite the topic, thinking of them as her friends still made her feel giddy, almost childishly so. Of course she would never admit it to anyone. She had a reputation to keep up.

She stood around in her room for a bit before sighing and deciding to leave. There wasn't much else for her to do other than explore. Though night would be a better time for really discovering the nooks and crannies of the place.

She came up to one of the main buildings, stepping inside. She wandered through the hallways until she came across one lined with statues. Angella was standing there, looking up at one of the figures. If she noticed Catra walk up next to her, she didn't react.

It looked kind of familiar. The face shape was like Glimmer's, but it obviously wasn't her. She was pretty sure she'd seen it in one of the murals in Bright Moon…

It clicked. “Is that Micah?”, she questioned.

“Yes.”, Angella replied, “He was the Head Sorcerer in Mystacor, until he married me and the title was passed to Castaspella.”

Catra’s gaze transitioned from Micah’s statue to the one next to it. Dust clung to it, and the stone was littered with scratches and chips. The black star it was holding seemed to have lost its luster long ago. Mystacor clearly did not want to honor this person.

“Who’s that?”, she asked, pointing at the statue. Angella turned towards it and her expression darkened. “Light Spinner. But you know her as Shadow Weaver.”

Catra quietly sucked in a breath. “Shadow Weaver used to live here?”

“Yes. I never met her, but she was Micah’s teacher. It doesn’t seem like she’s changed at all since then.”

The last part was said bitterly. Catra could tell there was more of a story behind that, but she didn’t press.

Angella looked back at her with a concerned frown. “Are you alright? What she did to you yesterday seemed to hurt a lot.” Catra blinked, a bit caught off guard by the question. “Yeah, I’m fine.”, she answered, “You should be more worried about Glimmer.”

“I’m able to be worried about more than one person.” That...She wasn’t sure what to think of that. They stood in silence for a little longer.

Angella wasn’t what Catra had expected.

She was a leader, a ruler, and a ruler was supposed to be imposing and command respect. Angella was certainly respected, but she didn’t threaten it out of people. She’d earned it.

Punishments could barely be called harsh. Comments from Glimmer were only answered with a disapproving look or a scold, and Catra had gotten much of the same treatment.

Angella wanting to be a part of the rescue mission was a surprise, but not an unwelcome one. At the time, Catra had been only thinking of everyone's skills and how to use them. But now she had a moment to look back.

Angella didn't take risks. It was easy to figure that out. She was one to keep hold of what they had instead of taking back what had been stolen. But she was primarily focused on Glimmer's safety.

Maybe that was why she wanted to help.

Catra stayed in the hall after Angella left. She couldn't keep her eyes off of Shadow Weaver's statue. Its condescending stare bore into her.

An indistinct whisper brushed by her ear, the prickly feeling of someone watching her rising up. She whirled around to face the seemingly empty area, unsheathing her claws. The shadows were darker than they had been before. They were closing in on her.

She couldn't move, *she couldn't move* --

"Catra?"

She yelped, leaping back and landing on all fours, her hackles raised. Bow was standing in front of her, looking torn between finding her action cute or concerning. "Are you ok?"

She quickly stood up, faking nonchalance. "Yeah, what's up?"

"Ok...Well, I was gonna go visit Glimmer. Do you wanna come too?" She nodded and followed after him.

They left the hall, but the feeling of eyes surrounding her did not.

They opened the door to Glimmer's room. She was sitting up in the bed, her usual clothes traded for a hospital gown. She jerked her head up, brightening when she saw them.

"Hey Glimmer.", Bow greeted, sitting down on the bed, "How are you doing?" "I'm good.", she answered, "I mean, I could be better, but I'm good. I'll probably be fine within a few days."

They hung out there for a while, avoiding the topic of...everything that had happened the morning before. Except, of course, Catra's admission to seeing them as her friends, which Bow excitedly recounted to Glimmer.

Their little moment of happiness was interrupted by Glimmer glitching.

"I'm fine, I'm fine!", she rushed to reassure once it was over, "It's not as bad as it looks."

Catra hesitated. "You don't have to lie.", she spoke, "I know it hurts."

Bow and Glimmer shared a look. "Did...Did Shadow Weaver do anything like this to you?", Glimmer asked quietly.

"Not exactly, but…", she curled a little smaller, "I know what her magic feels like."

Her thoughts were quickly silenced by the warmth of them hugging her.

They lost track time easily, but when the outside muted into cool blues and grays, Catra made her leave. Bow stayed behind a little longer.

Creeping across rooftops, she made her way through the floating city. There weren't any streetlamps, the moons' brighter than ever above the clouds.

She ended up perching on a windowsill, watching a group of kids setting off firework spells, laughing and shrieking with joy.

Mystacor was so full of magic, she would've thought it suffocating. But none of it was sharp or threatening, it was all just soft and flowy. Like a gentle breeze swirling around her.

Once the kids' little show was over, she continued on her way, balancing precariously on railings and the edge of buildings. But then felt something that nearly made her fall off.

Static in the air, making the fur on the back of her neck rise.

She slowly turned, seeing a red eye looking at her through a darkened window. She stepped back as several more creatures slithered out, joining together to form an ever familiar figure.

Shadow Weaver.

"Hello, *Catra.* " Only she could say her name like an insult.

"Wow, I sure pissed you off, huh.", Catra quipped, struggling to keep her voice even, "Was it because we got away or because Angella punched you in the face?"

Instead of deigning her with an answer, Shadow Weaver struck out, attempting to curl her magic around Catra. With a yelp, she jumped away, roughly landing in the street and breaking out into a sprint.

She wove through the streets to the guest building, leaping through a window into her room. She snatched the sword off the dresser.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!", she shouted frantically. There was a spark, but nothing happened. She frowned. It had never done

that before. She didn't stay frustrated for long, once again becoming overwhelmed with fear.

She dodged another attack, slamming open her door and running out into the hall. "Bow!", she yelled as she burst into his room. But he wasn't there. He was still with Glimmer.

"All alone, it would seem." Catra backed up further into the room, Shadow Weaver looming over her. "You always knew you'd end up like that, didn't you?"

She sent out another strike, and Catra held up the sword to block. To her surprise, it turned into a shield, her magic bouncing right off.

It didn't deter Shadow Weaver though, her onslaught continuing. Catra was forced to climb out onto the roof.

"That's right, run away!", Shadow Weaver taunted as she scaled higher, "It's the only thing you've ever been good at."

She did not reach safety on the rooftop, being met with another blast. She held up the shield to block.

"You were nothing before I took you in.", Shadow Weaver continued to slight, "And for all my efforts, you are *still* nothing."

"Is that your excuse?", Catra demanded, "Is that your justification for torturing a child? For trying to break me?"

"I only wanted to make you strong!"

"Well, congratulations!", the gem on the shield began to glow, "I'm plenty strong now. But that's not because of you. That's *despite* you."

Darkness swirled around her, Shadow Weaver towering far above. But she wasn't scared. The warmth of magic, her own magic, surrounded her. And she knew this time it would keep her safe.

She held up the shield, light emanating from it. “You can’t hurt me anymore!” The warmth shot out, chasing away the shadows and the fear. She felt triumph. And relief.

She fell to her knees, breathless. Rolling over onto her back, she looked up at the sky with a grin on her face.

She was gone.

She was safe.

Chapter End Notes

I think it could've been better, but it's good enough for me

Next Chapter:
Adora: https://youtu.be/EPS2C3SYLsY

A Trip Down Traumatic Lane

Chapter Notes

Waring: Child Abuse

And another note: I don't blame Adora at all for not seeing Catra was hurting. Catra wasn't exactly open about it, and Adora had her own shit to deal with. But this chapter is from Adora's POV, so obviously she blames herself for everything

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora stepped out of the training room, the younger cadets she'd been tasked with having left long ago. It was nice to be distracted for a little while.

At that thought, everything came flooding back.

She had been practically forced from the Black Garnet chamber. She didn't understand why. She wanted to be there when Catra was better. But she didn't want to risk disobeying Shadow Weaver again.

The door slid shut behind her and she barely wasted a moment to press her ear against it. She could hear Catra's muffled voice on the other side, the bite clear. Shadow Weaver's voice came next. It sounded sort of smug. Adora frowned. There was a moment of silence, and a bit of static in the air.

It was pierced by Catra crying out.

Adora frantically pressed the keypad, the door easily opening for her. She rushed inside, taking in the scene.

Shadow Weaver had her hands pressed to the sides of Catra's face, buzzing with magic. She didn't look phased by Catra's struggling at all.

“It will be over soon enough.”, she seemed to reassure, though her tone was more exasperated than soothing.

A burst of light shone, and in its place appeared the Queen of Bright Moon. Adora stood there, frozen as she watched her knock Shadow Weaver to the ground.

After she helped the princess off the ground, and undid the ties around Catra, they turned to finally notice her. The princess raised her fists and Catra clutched the sword, but Adora made no move.

When it was clear there was no fight to be had, the queen placed a hand on their shoulders and they all disappeared in another flash of light. That left Adora alone in the Black Garnet chamber with an unconscious Shadow Weaver and the faint residue of magic in the air.

It had been almost two days since that happened. Adora hadn’t seen Shadow Weaver since. And honestly? She was glad for that. She wasn’t sure what she’d say to her after seeing her respond so emotionlessly to Catra’s pain.

Scorpia had checked up on her earlier, and Adora gave the same answer as always. She was fine. She’d get another chance.

Did you really not notice your skiff keys were missing?

She had to believe that.

She had to get her back.

Adora was brought out of her thoughts by two noises. An odd trill sound from a robot (since when did they have purple lights?), and creak from the vents. She would’ve brushed off both, if she didn’t hear another creak. Then another. Making its way through the vent.

Narrowing her eyes, she followed the sound. It came by a vent grate, and she flipped it open, reaching in and dragging the person out.

Adora was met with a face full of purple.

“Uh, hi.”, the princess waved.

The door to the interrogation room slid open, allowing Adora and Scorpia to enter. Adora stood tall, trying to appear intimidating.

“What are the Rebellion’s plans?”, she said, getting straight to the point. The princess seemed unbothered by the sudden address, nor the fact she was currently a prisoner. She hummed in thought, then, surprisingly, answered.

“I don’t believe there are any plans, we’ve mostly been improvising as we go along. Though, I only joined the Rebellion recently and haven’t been involved in any meetings yet.”

Adora blinked at how easily the princess gave the information. It could always be a lie, but she wouldn’t be able to discern that.

Uncertainly, she tried a different question. “What are you doing in the Fright Zone?”

“Oh, I got separated from my friends a while ago, and since they had a hard time finding me before, I thought I should stay put to make it easier for them.”

“And how long ago was that?”

She hummed again, one of her pigtails slipping out of its cuff, taking a recorder off her belt. After listening to one of the audio clips, she concluded, “Forty-five hours.”

Adora’s shoulders sagged, suddenly feeling sad for the princess. There had been multiple accounts of the group leaving. They would know it was too much of a risk to return. They probably didn’t even look back, knowing one of their own had been left behind. “Entrapta, that’s almost two days. They aren’t here anymore.”

Her chipper mood faded into something unreadable. She clicked a button on her recorder and began speaking into it. "Fright Zone Log, hour 45. Is that right? It was hard to tell from the walls.", her face began to fall as it dawned on her, "Hour 45, that's-that's too many hours....They aren't coming back for me."

Adora looked away, remaining silent. She shared a glance with Scorpia, who only tilted her head question, evidently not having the same thought. Turning back to Entrapta, she tentatively suggested, "You could join the Horde."

Entrapta perked up slightly. "Join the Horde?"

"Yeah! We have a place for everyone here. You could--You're an engineer, right?"

"I consider myself more of a scientist, but engineering is a major part of it.", she corrected, "They should see, Horde technology gives me *so much* to work with. Emily's the most advanced bot I've ever built!"

"Who's Emily?"

"Oh, how rude. Allow me to introduce you."

A hole in the wall was Adora's first glimpse at how wild working with Entrapta would be.

This was the third time Adora had snuck out of the Fright Zone. The same whirlwind of excitement and fear from before was in her, but it was more subdued. She was getting used to this.

She wasn't sure if it was something she *should* get used to.

She knew she would have to be careful not to get caught. Even if this 'First Ones' tech turned out to be useful, she wasn't sure how much more going off on her own Shadow Weaver would tolerate.

It didn’t take long for her to have to abandon the skiff, the woods too thick to fly through. She didn’t know how long she wandered on foot, the day moon having gone down a while ago.

With each minute, she became more frustrated. The screen on Entrapta’s device fuzzed into static again. Adora shook it, returning it normal. Somehow her destination was even further away despite her *standing still* . She let out an angry groan, dropping the map onto the forest floor. She should’ve known better than to trust a princess. This was all probably some elaborate trap, gaining Adora’s sympathy and then sending her out into the Whispering Woods to die. That seemed like an evil princess-y thing to do.

She began forward, searching for the skiff. Surely if she just kept moving, she’d find it eventually.

After who knows how long, she came across a clearing. “Woah.”, she breathed, looking up at a large, crystalline building. Could this be what she had been looking for?

She walked up to it, examining it for some sign of a door. The pattern she stood on lit up beneath her feet, causing Adora to jump back. The square lowered into a ramp, revealing a tunnel. She poked her head inside. It seemed safe…

Cautiously, she stepped down into the passage. She only got a few feet from the door when it slid closed with a thud. Adora rushed back to it, but could see no way to get it open. She was trapped.

She turned back to the tunnel, the darkness oppressive. It was the only path she could take. With a bit of apprehension, she continued forward.

Thankfully, the entire building wasn’t dark. She soon arrived at a brightly lit chamber. “Hello?”, she called out, but the only response was her own echo. Right. This place was a ruin, there wouldn’t be anyone living inside.

She trailed the edges of the room, stopping in front of a pedestal with a diamond shaped crystal on it, lines running through it. Maybe this was some of the tech? It slipped easily out of it's slot, but the moment she took it out, the chamber was cast in a red light. "Unauthorized presence detected. Security protocol initialized.", a robotic voice rang out.

Adora whipped around frantically as the doors to the chamber started closing. She rushed to one, only to backpedal when hundreds of red eyes appeared in the dark, accompanied by several screeches.

She bolted for a different escape, sliding under a door just before it slammed down on her pursuers. Said pursuers were thumping against it, trying to break through. She turned away and kept running until she couldn't hear their angry screeches.

She slowed, leaning against a wall to catch her breath. As she took in her surroundings, Adora realized she was completely and utterly lost.

This was bad. She was trapped in a crumbling building, with who knows what hunting her, and zero clue if each room she passed through was taking her closer to freedom, or just deeper into the ruin.

The layout of the place was nonsensical, giving no indication of where she could be. The rooms themselves didn't make much sense either, some being long and cramped, others being huge and empty. A few just had pits that led to nothing.

She came to a new area, taking a couple steps inside. Well, she found the Infinite Darkness Room. That was all it seemed to be, no other entrances in sight.

She turned to leave, only to find the door was gone. Blackness pressed in, and she whirled around, looking for any source of light.

There was a small, glowing sphere. She walked over, kneeling down to inspect it. Its light increased suddenly, and she shielded her eyes. When she blinked them open, she found herself in the Fright Zone.

She glanced over the room in confusion. It looked like one of the storage areas, a worker stacking up crates off to the side. They took no notice of her.

Just as she was about to call out to them, she heard a quiet snicker. She looked to the noise, shocked to see a fifteen year old version of herself crouched behind some boxes, failing to suppress a grin.

The worker left the room and the teen Adora waved her hand. An also fifteen year old Catra dropped down from the ceiling. As the two began digging through the boxes, Adora realized what this was.

A memory.

The teen Adora gave an excited giggle, which was quickly shushed by Catra, but she was also smiling. "Be quiet, we don't wanna get caught.", she warned in a whisper.

"I *am* being quiet.", Adora argued in a significantly louder whisper. Catra rolled her eyes. "You are one of the noisiest people I've ever met."

Adora responded by sticking out her tongue, then returned to searching.

She opened another box and lit up. "Catra, look!" As the other teen made her way over, Adora pulled out a familiar red jacket, immediately trying it on. "It fits pretty well, I think."

Catra shrugged, and dug through the box herself. A grin came across face as she pulled out her signature mask. Present Adora reached for the real one hooked to her belt, thumbing it.

The worker came back in, shouting when they saw them. The two teenagers rushed out of the room with their prizes, laughing as they ran down the hall. Until they came to a particularly dark section.

“Adora, Catra.” They halted at the clipped tone, seeing Shadow Weaver standing in front of them. She looked down at the items they were holding. “Where did you get those?”

“We found them, ma’am.”, teen Adora answered, standing stiffly. “Well, you have no need for them.”, Shadow Weaver replied, holding out her hands. The two complied, giving her the jacket and the mask.

Then the world around her shifted, glitching in and out until it had changed to the barracks. Adora stood over a sleeping and still fifteen year old version of herself.

Catra silently came in moments later, holding something to her chest. She kneeled down by the bunk, nudging the other teen. “Hey, Adora.” Said girl lifted her head up, blinking awake. “Catra? What is it?”

In response, she held up the jacket and the mask. Adora gasped, sitting up and taking the jacket. “How did you get these?”

“Shadow Weaver let us have them. I managed to convince her.”

Catra let out a small sound of surprise as Adora hugged her. “Thank you.” She pulled back, and then frowned. “What’s that?”, she asked, pointing to a burn on Catra’s wrist. She quickly hid it behind her back.

“It’s nothing. I just got too close to some hot pipes.”

“Ok, well, be careful next time.”

As the two laid down to sleep, the memory faded out, and Adora was back in the First One’s ruin. She shook her head, quickly trying to orient herself.

That was weird. It seemed like the place could project her memories. It could be dangerous if she got caught up in one.

She continued forward, even more wary than she had been before.

As she walked down a long hall, she unhooked Catra's mask, looking down at it. There were so many little dents and scratches in the paint. Some had been there when they first found it, others were added over the years Catra owned it. So many memories…

Adora traced a scratch, wondering when and how it had gotten there. She was jerked from her musings when she ran straight into a wall. Stepping back and clutching her head, she looked around to see the familiar green and grays of her home. The barracks hall to be specific.

The rumble went through the walls. A thunderstorm, fairly common in the Fright Zone. The sound was accompanied by a small yelp. Adora followed the noise to her squadron's barracks, finding the source to be a seven year old Catra, next to an equally young Adora.

In a city of metal and machines, no one in the Fright Zone liked thunderstorms, least of all Catra.

There was another roll of thunder, causing Catra's fur to stand on end even further. "It's alright.", young Adora tried to sooth, "It's just thunder. You don't need to be scared."

"M'not scared.", Catra mumbled.

Despite that statement, she snuggled closer to Adora, giving a barely audible purr when the other girl pulled a blanket over them. Present Adora watched the two kids curled up together, listening to the sound of rain drumming against metal.

She shook herself. She was getting distracted, that was probably exactly what this place wanted. She needed to find a way out before--

Abruptly, all sound cut off. Except for a low chitter. Adora turned to the darkened passage, several glowing red dots being the only light. The barracks hall faded back into the ruins as the creature stepped out of the shadows, revealing itself to be a large spider.

She spun around and ran. She didn't get very far before something snagged her ankle, tripping her and sending her to the ground. She clawed at the floor as she was pulled closer to the spider.

Flipping onto her back, she extended her staff, cutting through the green rope that had her ensnared. It screeched angrily, lunging forward.

After a blur of tearing through metal and shattering glass eyes, the spider crumpled with a loud crash. Adora stood over it, breathing heavily. She relaxed her stance, absentmindedly picking some of the webbing off of herself.

And then once again was in the Fright Zone.

A maybe twelve or thirteen year old Adora was wandering the area. "Catra?", she called out, looking into closets and vent grates. Adora followed along. At first she thought it was a memory of them playing hide and seek, but the tween looked much too worried for that. Catra must've been missing.

She'd hidden off on her own multiple times, so it wasn't exactly telling as to what this was. Adora wracked her brain to try and figure out what memory this could be, but was brought out of her thoughts by a distant scream.

A scream that had been haunting her for the past two days.

Her younger self's worry morphed into fear, realizing who that was as well. She started running, following the cry. It led to a familiar, red and black door. The Black Garnet Chamber.

She frantically pressed the keypad, revealing the scene inside.

Catra was curled up on the floor, still yelling. Magic snapped and popped around her, filling the room with electricity. Shadow Weaver stood over her with her hand held out, giving no reaction.

Her head jerked towards Adora, and released her hold on Catra. She quieted, but stayed in a shaking ball. Adora was frozen, looking between the two. Then she quickly moved to kneel down next to Catra.

"Adora.", Shadow Weaver said sharply, "You aren't supposed to be here." She reached out towards her, but Adora reeled back. "Don't touch me!", she shouted, "Don't--Don't come near us!"

Shadow Weaver sighed, as if this was merely a childish tantrum. "Honestly Adora, how many times must we go through with this?" She waved a hand, and Adora stiffened.

"You will leave, and you *will not* come back. None of the events here concern you."

Catra slowly lifted her head up. "Adora?", she whispered tentatively. But the other girl didn't answer. Her eyes glazed over as she stood up and silently left the room.

She kept walking like that for a while. Then she blinked and stopped, looking confused as to where she was. Her bewilderment was soon shaken off when Catra appeared a few seconds later.

"Catra!", she called out, running up to her, "I was looking for you. Where have you been?" Catra's face twisted with anger and hurt. "You would know, wouldn't you.", she bit, shoving past.

Adora frowned, turning to follow. "What do you mean?"

"It doesn't matter, alright?", she snapped, "It doesn't *concern* you. Just *forget* about it."

The two continued down that hall and the projection ended, leaving Adora silent in shock.

That couldn't be real. She didn't remember any of that. Shadow Weaver wasn't exactly *nice* to Catra, but she would never--

Catra struggled against the straps, crying out. Shadow Weaver wasn't phased.

"Just forget *about it."*

"Shadow Weaver's been in your head for years and you're too stupid to see it!"

It wasn't real, it wasn't, *it wasn't* --

Adora ran. Ran away from the truth.

That Catra had been hurt far worse than she'd thought. That she never even noticed. That she *failed.*

She needed to get out of here. She needed this place to stop. Still, memories swirled around her, suffocating.

"I don't need *you to help me, I don't* need *you to protect me!"*

"I wasn't kidnapped, I wasn't brainwashed, I left on my own!"

"Just forget *about it."*

Adora screamed. " *Stop it!* "

Silence cut in and she stumbled to a stop. She looked around, finding herself back in the barracks. Sniffling came from a pile of blankets on one of the bunks.

"Catra?" Adora looked down to see her younger self entering the room. She walked over to the blanket, pulling it down to reveal a mane of hair and a hiss.

"It's ok, it's just me.", young Adora assured. She propped herself on the bed, sitting close. "It doesn't matter what they do to us, you know? You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing *really* bad can happen as long as we have each other."

The young Catra looked over to her. “You promise?”

Adora stared, shaking as she realized what memory this was. “I promise.”, her younger self replied. They sat there for a moment, holding each other close. Then the young Adora smiled. “Come on, let’s go back out.”

They stood, making their way out of the room. But before the younger Catra left, she looked up, straight at Adora who sucked in a breath. Her face was blank, almost curious, but Adora felt nothing but accusation in those eyes.

Because that promise had been broken long ago. And it was her fault.

The memory fell away, and she felt wind on her back. She turned to find a gaping hole in the wall, leading to the woods. Immediately, she rushed out and collapsed onto the grass, sobbing, not caring who might hear her.

Catra had left. And she was never coming back.

She couldn’t fix this.

When she returned to the interrogation room, which seemed to be quickly turning into an impromptu lab, Scorpia was immediately in her face. “What happened to you? You’re a mess! Have you been crying? Did something happen? Do you need to be tenderly nursed back to health???”

Adora pushed her away, but there wasn’t much force behind it. “I’m fine. Just...tired.”

Entrapta was next to shove herself too close. “How’d it go? Did you find anything?” Adora answered by pulling out the crystal she found. It wasn’t much, but it still made Entrapta squeal in excitement.

She turned to leave as Scorpia joined Entrapta in her celebration. “It’s like I was telling you, Adora is the best friend ever!”

She stumbled. “I’m going to bed.”, she murmured, “I’ll see you guys in the morning.”

Numbly, she walked back to her room. She unlooped Catra’s mask from her belt, placing it on the table beside her bed. Having enough mind to kick off her boots beforehand, she fell onto the mattress.

She was so, so tired.

Chapter End Notes

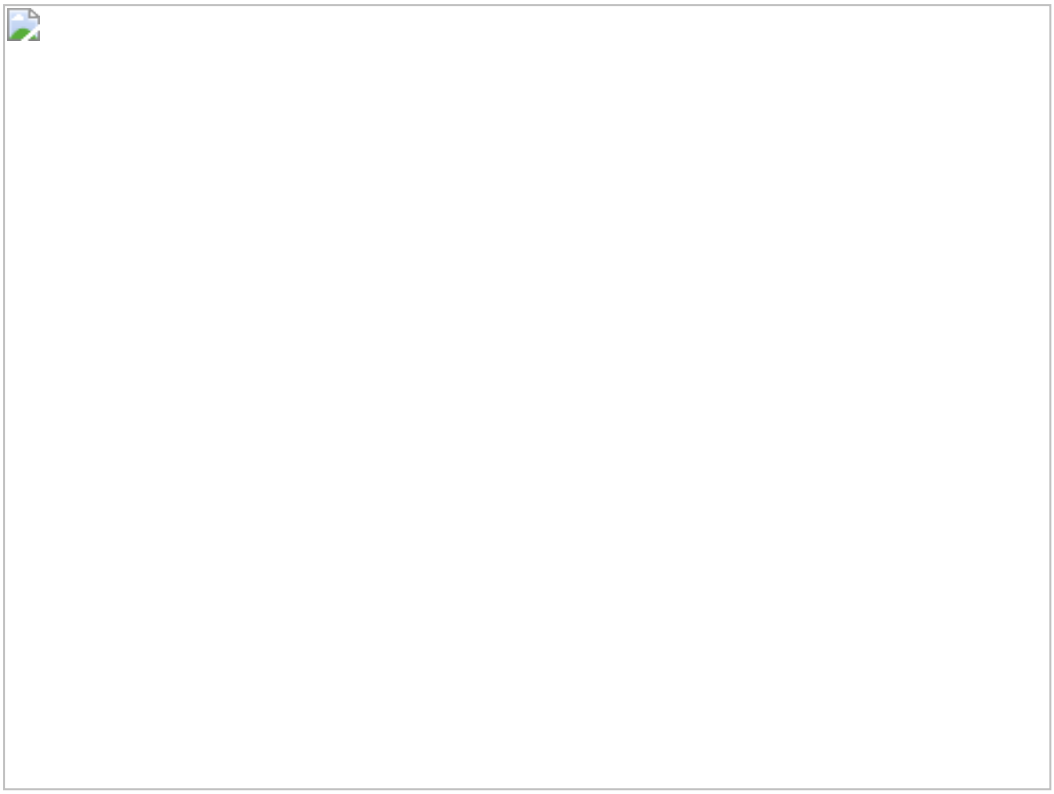
I saw you crying cause' of me, it made me lose my fucking mind...

I hope you all know I was grinning the entire time while writing this

Intermission: Catra's New Look

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes



Chapter End Notes

Yeah so, I mostly made this to say it'll probably be a while till the next chapter is done. It's already been three weeks, and I know what I wanna do I'm just not entirely sure how

Also I hate describing clothes and I didn't want to have to try and describe Catra's new outfit. So you get a drawing

Sorry if you were hoping for a new chapter, this one's been pretty slow going but it hopefully shouldn't take longer than mid July

My Therapist is a Cryptid

Chapter Notes

> Uggghhghghg I'm really, really not happy with this chapter. It feels kinda forced and maybe the pacing is a bit off? Idk, I have a hard time gaging pacing on my own work
>
> So yeah, this chapter is kind shit, but I've already spent a month on it and I can't think of anything better, so here ya go
>
> If you do have some idea of what I could do better, then let me know and I'll try to edit it some

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They were back in Bright Moon. Glimmer was...well she wasn't exactly *healed* , but she was better. The glitching had ceased, only happening when she tried to teleport (which was often) and other than that, she seemed fine.

Catra had gotten some new clothes. Such a small thing brought a smile to her face. The Horde hadn't given cadets much chance to differentiate themselves. Catra had gotten lucky to have her mask.

But her mood was soured when Perfuma came, asking if she could set up a memorial for Entrapta.

That led to now, Catra perched on a window above the gardens, watching as Perfuma silently weaved together vines.

She felt like she should be more upset. Well, obviously she was sad, why wouldn't she be? But she wasn't as downcast as the others were.

Maybe it was because she'd always expected something like this to happen, or she just didn't know Entrapta well enough. Either way, she felt a stab of guilt. Here she was, thinking about clothes and other such things, while everyone else grieved.

Her thoughts of the mission, Glimmer, and Perfuma intermingled, leading her to a memory of Plumeria, back when all this had only just started.

"The stories say that the She-ra could heal. Could you do that?"

Could she? She *had* healed Plumeria, though that was with Perfuma's help. She might be able to do the same for Glimmer.

Perfuma had assisted her before, and seemed to know about this kind of thing, but Catra wasn't really up for talking to her at the moment. Though there was that First One's ruin that seemed to be related to She-ra…

Catra left the window, resolute in her new course of action.

Catra had passed Bow in the hall, telling him where she was going and if she wasn't back by morning or something important happened, they should look for her.

She might very well be in the woods until dawn, seeing as she'd been walking in circles for what must've been hours. She should've asked Bow for his trackerpad. She couldn't believe she hadn't thought of it. Though with her luck, it probably wouldn't even have worked.

Just as she was about to accept that she was gonna be sleeping in the middle of the forest that night, she heard the distant sound of pots and pans clinking together.

Oh thank fuck, civilisation.

She started to run towards the noise, though as she got closer, she realized it didn't sound like a town. She could hear someone muttering, but that was about it.

Slowing, she took to the trees instead, soon finding herself looking down at a small house nestled beneath an outcropping.

An old woman dressed in purple was outside of it, sweeping the ground. She seemed to be the one talking to herself.

Suddenly, the woman paused her chore, lifting her head up to the canopy. And looking straight at Catra.

While Catra tensed, the woman greeted warmly, “Mara, dearie! I wasn’t expecting to see you today.”

Catra’s panic shifted to confusion. Before she could tell her that she’d never seen her in her life, nor knew who Mara was, the woman spoke again. “Well, come down then. You didn’t show up for berry picking the other day, we don’t want to waste anymore time.”

She seemed harmless enough, so Catra dropped from the tree, following her into the small hut. “Uh, my name’s Catra actually, I don’t know who Mara is. Have you seen any giant, crystal ruins around here?”

The woman turned back to her, squinting as if she was finally seeing her. “No, you don’t know Madame Razz, do you?”, she, Madame Razz apparently, questioned, “It’s the wrong time for my Mara, isn’t it? And now you have the sword.”

Catra shifted at the mention of the weapon strapped to her back, her confusion and frustration only growing. Razz’s demeanor suddenly flipped, going from reminiscent to cheerful. “Well, you’re here now and there are still berries to be picked!”, she declared, shoving a basket into Catra’s arms.

She frowned at the object, holding it out. Then she let it drop to the ground, following Razz outside.

She was already making her way through the forest, on a determined path Catra couldn’t see. Catra pushed her way through the brush, struggling to keep up. How in the world was this woman so fast?

“Can you just tell me where to go?”, she called from behind, “I don’t really care what kind of landmark, I just need directions to *somewhere* .” Razz laughed in response. “Oh dearie, there is no direction in the Whispering Woods except forward.”

Catra huffed. Cleary Razz wasn’t going to be helpful. She stopped, looking out at the darkening treeline, unknown creatures laying just beyond.

...Maybe sticking with a crazy old person would be better than being alone.

She ran to catch up, slowing to scan the trees for any sign of the ruin. She didn’t get much of a chance to see anything before a broom wacked her in the head.

“Ow, hey!”

“Quit looking so hard.”, Razz scolded, “You’ll never find what you’re searching for if you look for it.” That didn’t make a whole lot of sense, but ok.

Razz somehow materialized a second basket, holding it out to her. “Take a break, dearie. Berry picking is a good time to think.” Catra sighed, but obliged, begrudgingly taking the offered item.

Apparently she was picking berries with a stranger in the middle of the Whispering Woods. Yep, that was what her life had come too.

Once they’d reached a berry patch, Catra began to absentmindedly pick the fruit. She wasn’t sure how much she was supposed to gather. Maybe just fill up the basket? Razz would probably decide when they were done.

It did briefly occur to her that she had no idea what berries were good and what wasn’t. But that wasn’t really her problem, so she shrugged and carried on.

She moved on from her bush, searching for a new section of the patch. She weaved through the trees, stopping at the sight she was met with. It wasn't the ruin she was looking for, but it was a familiar one.

"How dare *you! How can you just look at your destruction and act like it's nothing?"*

"It's a war *, princess. Something's gonna get broken along the way."*

That was three weeks ago. Three weeks ago she stood here and felt nothing.

"It's not my life, why should I?"

Did she even feel anything now?

There was a robot at her feet, bent and broken, plant life clinging to it. She kicked it in frustration, denting it further.

She'd gotten distracted. Entrapta hadn't even crossed her mind in hours, when that should've been all she was thinking about.

(Finding a way to heal Glimmer had been her focus. It was important, but so was Entrapta)

She kicked the robot harder, repeating the motion as her anger rose.

"You're only hurting yourself, dearie.", came Razz's voice from beside her. "I don't care.", Catra bit, but she stopped anyway.

Razz placed a hand on her arm. "Come now, tell me what's wrong."

"I don't *know* !", Catra burst out, "Everyone's acting like they're fine, but that's all it is, acting. But I *am* fine, when I shouldn't be. They're all so upset, and I'm just...not.", she sank to the ground, "It feels like I'm heartless."

She was surprised when she was once again wacked with the broom.

"Hey!"

"Quit talking nonsense, dearie. You don't have to feel the same as anyone else."

"What?"

"Emotions are...eh, not the most rational things. Perhaps one day the grief of your loss will come, but it is alright if you're moving on now. It is alright to feel better."

Catra scrubbed away her forming tears (she was *not* going to cry in front of some random stranger) The advice didn't make much sense to her, and her mood didn't improve. But maybe that would change.

Razz waited patiently as she calmed her breath. Catra finally gathered herself, standing back up. She was surprised when a glow began to form in the treeline. She stepped towards it, looking out to see the source was the First Ones Ruin.

Huh. Not looking really did help her find it.

She spared a glance back to Razz, who waved her forward. "Go on, dearie. This place can answer many of your questions. Do beware, though. The ghost can be mean."

Catra blinked at that, but only shook her head in response. She turned back to the ruin, walking up to it to look for a door. She found the entrance was actually beneath her, leading into a tunnel. And that tunnel led to the chamber with the She-ra mural.

After a frustrating few minutes with the hologram, she was met with someone who could actually help her.

Though much less helpful than she hoped.

Light Hope paused in her speech, and Catra took the moment to interrupt her. “That’s really useful information and all, but I mostly came here to ask something specific.”

“What is your question?”

“How do I heal?”

“You will learn about your powers during your training.”, Light Hope simply responded. Catra gave an irate sigh.

“Can’t we just skip to the healing now?”

“We cannot. There is a specific order to your training, and we must start from the beginning.”

She dragged a hand down her face. “And how long would this training take?”

“Years.”

“ *Years?* I can’t stay here for years!”

“You must. The world cannot afford an untrained She-ra--”

“You said Etheria needs me. Well, Etheria needs me *now* .”, Catra argued, “I can’t stay holed up here for years while a war is still going.”

“When would you have a chance to train?”

She took a breath. “We could set up a schedule. I can come here and train for a couple hours everyday, giving you enough time to teach me, and me enough time to do other things.”

Light Hope frowned in thought. Catra kept her gaze forward and steady during the silence. “...I will consider it. Return here tomorrow, and we can discuss this further.”

Catra’s shoulders sagged in relief, and she blinked to find herself back in the ruin. Being only met with quietness, she turned to

leave. As the ramp lowered and she stepped outside, she realized she’d never actually learned anything about healing.

That thought was soon swept away in the blizzard that was raging around her.

Chapter End Notes

I won't go into too much detail, but a couple months ago one of my relatives died and these were a few of my thoughts on it. My mom told me it was fine, and it was a few years until she well and truly missed and cried over one of her dead relatives

It wasn't a take on character death I'd seen before, and I thought it'd fit with Catra and be a little more interesting than just blaming herself for everthying

There might be one or two chapters after this, I don't really know. This section is super fuzzy, plus I'm working on other writing projects, so it might be a month or so until the next update

Owe

Chapter Notes

> Me: Tags works as Slow Updates so I won't have to worry about writing quickly
> Also me: Worries about writing quickly
>
> Tho considering that I finished this within 3 weeks while also working on a completely different fic, I think I made pretty good time
> (Please don't worry about me burning myself out, I promise I take plenty of breaks)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora paused in her work, taking a moment to step back and look over the Black Garnet. Entrapta was typing away on the computers, while Scorpia was also helping hook cables and other such things to the Runestone. It still felt unnerving to be there, even though she knew they had permission.

Well, not Shadow Weaver's permission, but that didn't really matter much anymore.

She looked off to the side, down at the spot where the memory from the ruin had happened. She hadn't been able to get the image out of her head. There'd always been rumors about what Shadow Weaver could do. Mind wiping was amongst them, but she hadn't believed it anymore than the other stories.

Catra was right. She was an idiot.

" *What is the meaning of this?* ", hissed a voice Adora had been dreading the moment she'd returned. Instinctually, she stiffened, turning to see Shadow Weaver pounding her way in

Scorpia stumbled for an explanation, but was quickly shushed, Shadow Weaver gliding up to address Adora.

"Did you really think you could invade my inner sanctum without me noticing?", she demanded, "I'd expect such behavior from Catra, but *you* ? Honestly Adora, I thought you were better than this."

"Honestly Adora, how many times must we go through with this?"

How many times? How many times had her memory been stolen away? How many times had Catra gotten hurt and she remained clueless?

Shadow Weaver loomed over her, trying to appear intimidating. But Adora stood her ground. It was far too late for her to do this, but she could at least try. For Catra's sake.

And her own.

Adora took a breath, gathering whatever confidence she'd been preparing. "You have no power over me anymore.", she started evenly, not looking away, "Nor the Black Garnet. We've been given permission to experiment with it."

Shadow Weaver was practically shaking with rage. " *Whose* permission?"

"Mine."

The screens in the room flicked on, revealing Hordak, who briskly told her the news. That the Black Garnet was theirs to use. That Shadow Weaver no longer had ownership of it.

The lights and screens in the room burst, the torrent of raining glass hardly enough to cover Shadow Weaver's roaring, " *NO!* "

Adora covered her head with her hands, shards biting into them. She didn't pay attention to that, though, instead looking up as Shadow Weaver stepped up to the Black Garnet.

"Don't let her touch--" But Adora's warning fell on deaf ears as she slammed her palms against the gem, the rising electricity in

the air making everyone's hair stand on end.

Blackness encircled the room, barring off any exits. Scorpia attempted to charge at Shadow Weaver, only to be blasted back, tied down with red restraints. Entrapta and Emily were also quickly put in the same predicament.

Shadow Weaver tried to do the same to Adora, only for her to dodge out of the way. She swore she could feel the spike of anger. "After everything I've done for you, *this* is how you repay me?"

A blast sailed past her, narrowly missing. "Everything you've done for me?", Adora parroted as she ducked away, "You never cared about me, you never cared about anyone!" Stupid, stupid, stupid--

Another blast. "I *gave* you all your opportunities.", Shadow Weaver yelled. A far too close whip of lightning. "You wouldn't be anything you are today if not for me!"

Whatever luck she seemed to have grasped ran out, darkness curling around her and yanking her back towards Shadow Weaver. Adora could see that her hands were already searing with magic.

" *You owe all that you are to me!* "

"I don't owe you anything!"

Palms were pressed against the sides of her head, burning into her skull. She could feel the magic digging at her core, ready to rip her apart. No no no, not this--

Adora twisted in the grip, extending her staff with blind aim. It seemed to hit its mark, as an agonized wail rang out and Adora was dropped to the floor.

She scrambled to pull herself up, looking down to see that she had shattered the gem on Shadow Weavers mask, her struggling to put the scattered pieces back together. Adora breathed heavily, only able to stare at the action. The other three in the room were picking themselves up, Scorpia making eye contact with her.

She stood straight, attempting to put on an air of calm. “Scorpia, restrain her.”

Shadow Weaver barely fought as she was dragged out of the room. As she was, Adora let out a deep sigh of relief. She was gone. She would never have to see her again.

“Entrapta,”, she started as she turned to the woman. She seemed to have already recovered from the whole ordeal, once again fiddling with her instruments. Adora gestured to the controls. “If you would.”

Entrapta grinned and pulled down her goggles.

Bow and Catra burst into the war room, wet, cold, and out of breath. They took their seats at the table, Catra not wasting a moment to ask, “What’s happening?”

“The elements are out of harmony.”, Angella explained, “The Moonstone is using all its power to counteract the growing cloud of darkness, but it’s not enough.” “The Horde is definitely behind this.”, Glimmer said resolutely, “The cloud is coming from the Fright Zone.”

Catra looked down at the map, frowning. “The woods are completely frozen over.”, she said, “Nothing is stopping the Horde from getting to Bright Moon. They *won’t* waste this opportunity.”

Strangely, Glimmer perked up at that. “Oh, Bow! You know what this means?” She hopped out of her seat, grabbing Bow and (after a brief moment where she tried to teleport) began to drag him out of the war room.

“Where are you going?”, Catra asked. “To the armory.”, Glimmer called back.

“You mean the weapon stash in your closet?”

“Don’t tell my mom about that!”

Catra snickered quietly as they left, but the good moment quickly faded. She turned back to Angella, serious once again. “Do we know if any of the Alliance is coming?”

“Perfuma is still here, and is currently with Spinnerella and Netossa, who arrived recently.”, Angella answered, “I have not received a response from Mermista, but her kingdom is most likely facing this storm as well.”

As Angella nodded to a guard to get the other three princesses, Catra gathered whatever knowledge of Horde tactics she had, and began preparing for the biggest fight yet.

Chapter End Notes

> For some reason when Spinnerella and Netossa showed up, I got the vibe one of them was Bow's cousin??? Idk why, just the way Bow reacted to them made them seem like they were related
>
> (Tho, Spinnerella and Netossa don't have kingdoms...So they're families probably traveled around Etheria a lot...And that could lead a member of one of the families to gain an interest in all the historical things they came across...And when they decided they wanted nothing to do with the Rebellion, they might settle down with their husband in a library in the Whispering Woods.....We'll see if this ever becomes relevant)

The End (For Now)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Tidal waves, fire storms, earthquakes…", Scorpia listed off as she and Adora looked over the computers, "Man, Etheria's taking this *hard* ."

Entrapta was spinning around the room, rambling about the results behind them, but Adora didn't bother to try and decipher what she was saying. She was too busy looking at one of the screens playing footage of the Whispering Woods.

It was completely frozen over, wind whipping and trees crashing down. It created an almost clear path to Bright Moon. Their main defense was so easy to break through now.

"We could make it to Bright Moon.", she spoke out loud, mostly to herself. At her words, Scorpia followed her gaze, studying the woods herself. "Oh, wow, we could.", Scorpia said in almost wonder, "Should we tell Lord Hordak?"

Adora gave a nod. "Definitely"

Scorpia left, but Adora stayed focused on the screen. Focused on the plans forming in her head, and quieting every other thought of the last few hours.

They could take down Bright Moon.

Catra's tail lashed back and forth as the minutes ticked by, scanning the trees. Waiting. That was all they had left to do.

They'd already set up defenses around Bright Moon, had everyone armed and positioned. So now they were all facing what was left

of the Whispering Woods, waiting. Because it was inevitable the Horde would show up.

She knew Bow and Glimmer kept looking over to her, but she didn't say anything. And neither did they. Everyone was silent with anticipation.

Any second.

...

Any--

A blast of green energy sailed from the treeline.

It collided with the vines Perfuma had set around Bright Moon, a large bang following. And with that bang, the battlefield erupted.

Bots and tanks poured into view, skiffs sailing forward. The Bright Moon soldiers followed their actions, rushing to meet them.

Catra jumped down from her post, landing in the shallow water, barely taking a moment of pause before she was in motion with everyone else.

Swiftly cutting through bots and skiffs, her mind went blank with the familiar practices. Though this time it wasn't just a simulation for some test she'd pretended not to care about. It was all real.

Dodge.

Jump.

Swing.

It was somewhat of a rhythm, one she knew. But she also knew not to get too caught up in it.

Her ear flicked up as she heard something fly towards her, shifting the sword into a shield just in time to block the blast. The force

threw her back, but she was quick to get back on her feet, heading towards the tank targeting her.

Dodge.

Duck.

Jump.

Swing.

She easily ripped through the metal and the tank went down.

There was a mechanical whir of another tank rolling up behind her, and she whirled around to face it. But the sight she was met with made her pause.

Standing on top of the tank, dressed in Horde armor, was Adora.

Catra pulled on a grin. “Hey Adora.”, she drawled, “I figured you wouldn’t miss a fight like this.”

Adora remained silent, still staring at her with an almost sad look. A bit of concern wormed its way into Catra at the lack of reaction, but she kept up the cocky demeanor.

“What, no speech?”, she jeered, “No ‘Oh Catra, I’m here to save you from the Rebellion--”

“I don’t know why you joined the Rebellion.”

Catra faltered at that, blinking up at Adora with confusion and shock. Adora continued.

“But...I think I know why you left the Horde.”, she looked away, “And I’m sorry. I won’t try to bring you back.” Extending her staff, she got into a fighting position.

“Even though it means we have to be enemies.”

Catra narrowed her eyes and lowered into her own stance, all previous humor gone.

And the fight began.

An hour later, Adora, Scorpia, and Entrapta were walking up to Hordak's throne, their steps ringing against the metal. They stalled at the top, waiting for Hordak to address them.

"Force Captain,", he began, "It seems your experiment has failed."

"On the contrary!", Entrapta was quick to interrupt, "The experiment was a *huge* success, I know more about First Ones Tech than ever! This is just the beginning."

There was a pause in the air, and Hordak titled his head to Adora. She took it as an indication to speak, gathering at what arguments and reasonings she'd been thinking of on the way back.

"The woods are still in ruins, and we were able to cause significant damage to Bright Moon.", she started, "And like Entrapta said, we know more about First Ones Tech than anyone else. We might not have won, but we didn't lose either."

Hordak remained silent, and Adora felt her heartbeat quicken with each passing second. Then he stood.

"Very well, Force Captain Adora. You will have other chances to prove your worth to me.", he paused, "As my second in command."

Adora blinked. She hadn't been expecting that.

But she'd be an idiot to turn such an offer down, so she nodded her head. "Thank you, Lord Hordak."

She took a breath, a new weight settling on her shoulders.

It was like Entrapta said.

This was just the beginning to so much more.

Chapter End Notes

Holy shit, I actually completed something??? I mean, I got more to write, but Book 1 is done! Within a year!

This chapter is pretty short, but there weren't a lot of changes necessary or that I felt like writing. Also I just wanted to get it done so I'd have a good stopping point for a hiatus.

Yeah, this series is going on hiatus.

Idk for how long, just until I get back into the She-ra vibe or something close. Which could be a while.

But until then, I hoped you enjoyed Book 1!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!